The Effect of a Woman-Friendly Occupation on Employment: U.S. Postmasters Before World War II *

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July 7, 2026

Abstract

This paper studies U.S. postmasters in the early twentieth century, a rare woman-friendly occupation at a time when women's employment opportunities were highly constrained. Using a novel dataset linking postmaster appointments to census records, I show that these well-paid, flexible positions attracted educated and qualified White women into the labor force. However, exploiting exogenous variation in reappointment probabilities through an RD design, I find that many women exited the labor force once their appointments ended. Few transitioned into other skilled occupations, accounting for only one-third of the 24 pp. employment loss. The results are consistent with a reservation-wage mechanism: women who secured alternative full-time skilled jobs with wages comparable to postmasters remained employed, while others stopped working. The scarcity of jobs similar to postmasters likely limited the long-term gains of this otherwise advantageous occupation.

JEL Codes: N32, J16, J24, J44

*I thank the editor Brian Beach and the referees for their valuable comments and suggestions. I am especially grateful to James Feigenbaum, Bob Margo, and Johannes Schmieder for their guidance throughout the project. The paper also benefited from feedback of Abhay Aneja, Martin Fiszbein, Claudia Goldin, Grant Goehring, Max Garcia, Shresth Garg, Kevin Lang, Nayeon Lim, Ben Marx, Carolyn Moehling, Greg Niemesh, Daniele Paserman, Pascual Restrepo, Mara Squicciarini, Anthony Wray and seminar participants from Boston University, Harvard University, the University of Southern Denmark, the World Cliometric Conference, the EHA Meeting, the SEA Meeting, the SOLE Meeting, and the EHS Conference. I appreciate Jennifer Lynch and Stephen Kochersperger from the USPS historian's office for answering many of my questions. All errors are my own.

1 Introduction

Women often face the challenge of balancing labor force participation with domestic responsibilities, and many experience substantial marriage and child penalties in their careers (Kleven et al., 2024). In response to these constraints, a growing literature examines whether employment in occupations with more woman- and family-friendly features, such as flexibility or predictable hours, can mitigate these issues and improve women's labor market outcomes (Goldin and Katz, 2016; Mas and Pallais, 2017; Wiswall and Zafar, 2017; Wasserman, 2022).

This paper extends this literature by examining a historical case: U.S. postmasters between 1920 and 1940, a rare woman-friendly occupation in an era when employment opportunities for women were severely constrained. Unlike many skilled professions that imposed marriage bars, postmasters hired married women and offered relatively high salaries along with flexible work arrangements. How did access to a well-paid, flexible, and socially acceptable job affect women's employment? Because the postmaster positions were disproportionately accessible to women from privileged backgrounds, this paper therefore focuses on this advantaged group, who were best positioned to leverage a woman-friendly job at a time when broader labor market barriers remained substantial.

To study postmasters, I compile a novel dataset of postmaster appointments between 1920 and 1940 using the archival source "Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832-1971" (National Archives and Records Administration, 1977), which provides detailed information on postmaster names, postmaster appointment dates, and post office locations. I link postmasters appointed during this period to complete-count decennial census records using a conservative matching criterion. Using the linked data, I show that postmaster jobs attracted educated and qualified White women into the labor force. On average, women postmasters had 11.7 years of schooling, placing them above the 70th percentile in the education distribution, yet only 32.5% had engaged in paid employment prior to their appointments. Women postmasters also appear positively selected on business experience: among those who were married, 47.3% had self-employed husbands, suggesting that many may have acquired managerial skills through unpaid work in family-run businesses.

Despite drawing an advantaged group of women into the occupation, I next show that postmaster jobs offered limited long-term benefits to women's employment beyond the appointed term. To identify these effects, I exploit the fact that postmasters were presidential appointees and were rarely re-appointed after the party of the president changed (Kernell and McDonald, 1999; Blevins, 2021). I implement a regression discontinuity (RD) design centered on the 1933 presidential transition, comparing the 1940 labor market outcomes of women appointed just before and just after the change in administration. Women postmasters appointed just before the 1933 transition were largely unable to secure additional terms due to political misalignment with the new administration, whereas those appointed just after the transition were more likely to be reappointed and often remained in office beyond 1940.

The sharp and fuzzy RD estimates show that many women did not find new employment after their postmaster appointments ended. In particular, these women experienced at least a 24 percentage points (pp.) reduction in employment, along with reductions of 17 weeks worked per year and 11 hours worked per week. Nonetheless, some women did transition into other skilled occupations—such as clerical work and bookkeeping—suggesting that the skills acquired as postmasters were transferable. A simple decomposition shows that about one-third of the decline in employment was mitigated by such occupational substitution, while the remaining two-thirds reflected true labor force exits. In contrast to the substantial decline in women's employment, men appointed under similar conditions experienced little to no reduction in employment or labor supply. These gender gaps are both large and statistically significant, indicating that the negative effects observed for women were not driven by selection issues related to politics, but rather reflected gender-specific labor market constraints.

I complement the RD analysis with a difference-in-differences (DID) design, comparing the 1940 employment outcomes of women with postmaster experience to those of their 1920 women neighbors. Conditional on neighborhood sorting, this comparison primarily reflects within-group differences among educated, White, high-status women. The DID estimates show that women with postmaster work experience did not achieve better long-term employment outcomes than their neighbors after their appointments ended.

Both the RD and DID results are consistent with a job search framework featuring a reservation-wage mechanism, in which women remained employed only when they received alternative job offers that exceeded their reservation wages. Consistent with this interpretation, I find that post-appointment employment declines were driven by exits from full-time and skilled work rather than transitions into part-time employment, and that conditional on re-employment, women earned wages comparable to those of women who remained postmasters. Heterogeneity analyses further support this mechanism: employment declines were larger among women from higher socioeconomic backgrounds, who likely had higher reservation wages, and among women in states which introduced legislation against married women working or in areas more severely affected by the Great Depression, where acceptable job opportunities were particularly scarce. Together, these findings suggest that women were more likely to exit the labor force when acceptable alternative employment was unavailable.

The findings of this paper align with a related literature showing that early expansions in women's employment often failed to translate into sustained labor force participation once similar occupations became unavailable (Rose, 2018; Boter and Woltjer, 2020). However, as restrictions on women's work eased during the second half of the 20th century, the range of occupations open to women expanded significantly, thereby supporting women's long-term participation in the labor market. If we were to study the postmaster occupation during a later period, we would likely observe more positive outcomes, as many former women postmasters could transition into other skilled and white-collar occupations.

This paper makes two main contributions to the literature. First, it leverages rich archival data to shed light on women's historical work—much of which has remained invisible either because it was not classified as "gainful employment" or because many women participated in the labor force only temporarily (Goldin, 1990; Folbre, 1995; Burnette, 2021).[1] By uncovering a group of women who served as postmasters and played critical roles in the operation of U.S. post offices, this study contributes to the growing literature that documents women's historical labor, including work in agriculture (Withrow, 2021), as telephone operators (Feigenbaum and Gross, 2024), and as family workers (Chiswick and Robinson, 2021). Second, this paper advances the discussion on woman-friendly occupations. While conventional wisdom holds that such roles support women's employment, few studies offer empirical evidence (Goldin, 2014; Goldin and Katz, 2016; Mas and Pallais, 2020). This paper addresses this gap by leveraging a unique natural experiment to overcome the challenge of endogenous selection of women into these occupations, thereby providing stronger causal evidence on their impact on women's employment.

[1] For example, the 1940 Census reports women were more likely to drop out of the labor force during the Depression, making it more difficult to study women who worked (United States Census Bureau, 1943).

2 Historical Background

Postmasters are federal government employees who manage local post offices, and each post office has one postmaster. The postmaster's duties include selling stamps, processing money orders, managing receipts, and overseeing various administrative functions. In this paper, references to postmasters between 1920 and 1940 specifically concern those overseeing offices with relatively high mail volumes and working full-time in the position. Approximately 12,000 postmasters met these criteria during this period.[2] Very few postmasters were Black, however, owing to systemic barriers and racial discrimination (National Postal Museum, 2025). Accordingly, the analysis in this paper only focuses on White individuals.

2.1 Postmasters as Presidential Appointees

Postmasters were presidential appointees whose political affiliations typically aligned with that of the appointing President. During the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, postmasters played significant roles under the spoils system to help their party win elections, including inserting residents' mail with campaign materials and endearing "themselves to members of the House of Representatives through their regular, personal contact with a remote segment of the electorate" (Kernell and McDonald, 1999). In return, presidents rewarded party loyalists with postmaster appointments after electoral victories. As valuable political assets, postmasters became the single largest group of political appointees (John, 1988). Between 1819 and 1917, they accounted for 76.6% of all presidential appointments, far exceeding the number of appointments made to any other federal department (Blevins, 2021). The politics involved in postmaster appointments was never a secret: the Postmaster General James Farley, who served under President Franklin Roosevelt, noted that his selection of postmasters had to be "loyal Democrats who at the same time will have the ability to serve in their positions to the credit of their party and their country" (Farley, 1938).

The political nature of the position meant that reappointments were extremely rare following a presidential transition involving a change in the party of the president. However, postmasters were not immediately removed from office after the transition, and they were allowed to complete the appointed term, which typically lasted four years. Given the relatively high pay of the

[2] Additional details on the postmaster sample used in the paper are provided in Section 12.1 of the Appendix.

position, most had a strong financial incentive to remain in office until the end of their term.

Despite being political appointees, candidates for postmasters had to demonstrate merit by passing civil service exams (Patch, 1948).[3] The exam tested the candidate's ability to manage the post office, such as their arithmetic and writing skills. For example, the candidate was asked to make an itemized list of money order transactions over the past month, as well as to balance and close the statement based on fees charged in each money order (United States Civil Service Commission, 1916). Candidates applying for postmastership in larger post offices additionally had to demonstrate "business training, experience, and fitness" and "the ability in meeting and dealing satisfactorily with the public" (United States Civil Service Commission, 1922).[4]

However, even after the introduction of civil service reform, the postmaster position remained politically influenced for many decades. The president was permitted to appoint any of the top three exam scorers to the position. In practice, presidents overwhelmingly selected candidates from their own party rather than from the opposition. When no suitable appointees appeared among the top candidates, a second examination was often administered (United States Government Printing Office, 1935). Because presidents were not necessarily familiar with the party affiliations of applicants, the Postmaster General or local members of Congress frequently played a key role in identifying and recommending candidates aligned with the president's party (Fowler, 1945; Kernell and McDonald, 1999).

As a result, postmaster selection reflected a combination of political affiliation and other qualifications. Some appointments were driven by strong partisan ties. For example, Mrs. Anne Parsal of Benton Harbor, Michigan, secured the postmaster position through her active role in the local Democratic campaign during the 1932 election. When she was appointed in 1935, Parsal was photographed with a portrait of Franklin Roosevelt on her desk, a visible signal of her loyalty to the Democratic president (The Herald-Palladium, 1935). Most women postmasters, however, were far less involved in local party politics. These women resided in rural areas and were distant from the center of political attention. To establish political credentials required for the job, women often invoked the party affiliations of male family members—for example, noting that their husbands, fathers, or brothers had voted for the party (Aron, 1987). At the same time,

[3]This rule still applies to postmaster selection today, as suggested by the USPS employment and placement handbook: https://about.usps.com/handbooks/el312

[4]Section 12.2 of the Appendix explains the eligibility requirements for postmaster candidates and the content of the civil service exams in more detail.

women postmasters were frequently drawn from self-employed households, such as those in which a husband "operates a general merchandise store" (Herald and Review, 1938) or where the appointee was the widow of "a former grocer in the village" (Marysville Journal-Tribune, 1926). These patterns suggest that women's business experience, alongside political affiliations, played an important role in securing postmaster appointments.

2.2 Postmaster as a Woman-Friendly Occupation

The postmaster occupation had several woman-friendly characteristics that made it more accommodating to women than other skilled occupations of the time. Most notably, it was open to both unmarried and married women, a rare exception at a time when marriage bars were widespread in skilled employment.[5] In the decades leading up to World War II, opposition to married women's employment was strong, driven by concerns that working mothers neglected domestic responsibilities and displaced other workers (Aron, 1987; Wandersee, 1981). In contrast, the postmaster position remained accessible to married women through several institutional features. These included the appointment of women during wartime when men were less available, as well as civil service guidelines that gave favorable consideration to wives of active military members or veterans, although appointment was not guaranteed (Gallagher, 2017; Blevins, 2021; United States Civil Service Commission, 1938). Additionally, the emphasis on prior business experience advantaged women from self-employed households, particularly wives who had gained relevant experience through family businesses (United States Civil Service Commission, 1922).[6]

The postmaster position was also relatively well-paid for women. Salaries were calculated as a percentage of post office sales and did not vary by the gender of the postmaster.[7] Although women were primarily appointed to smaller, rural post offices with lower revenue and corre-

[5] Shallcross, 1940 documents that most insurance companies, banks, and public entities restricted the employment of married women, and Goldin, 1988 finds that marriage bars "affected 75% of all local school boards and more than 50% of all office workers" at its height.

[6] Although the federal government did not provide the exact reason why it allowed women and married women to enter the postmaster job, it acknowledged the growing number of women in the occupation, which was first mentioned in the Annual Report of the Postmaster General in 1924 (United States Post Office Deptartment, 1924).

[7] In particular, the formula for postmaster salary is "40% for sales under \$100, 33.3% for sales from \$100 to \$400, 30% for \$400 to \$2,400, 12.5% for sales over \$2,400" (Prechtel-Kluskens, 2007). The lack of wage discrimination was proudly stated by the President of the National Federation of Postal Employees in 1919: "There is no discrimination against her in the matter of wages. We, as an organization, will resist any such discrimination, should it be made" (The National Federation of Postal Employees, 1919).

spondingly lower pay,[8] they still earned at least $1,100 per year and sometimes as much as $2,000 to $3,000 (United States Civil Service Commission, 1938). By comparison, women in other skilled occupations generally earned less, with average salaries around $800 for clerical workers, $900 for stenographers, and $1,100 for teachers.[9]

Finally, the postmaster position offered flexible work arrangements. Because most post offices were located in rural areas, postmasters had considerable discretion over the location of their office. Many chose to operate the post office within a family-run general store or even from their own homes (Blevins, 2021).[10] This flexibility distinguished women postmasters from other working women and contributed to the perception of the role as a "clean and honorable" occupation that allowed them to stay closely connected to their homes and families (Cortelyou, 1906). By blurring the boundary between home and workplace, the position also shielded married women from criticism that wage work necessarily entailed neglect of domestic responsibilities.

In the context of the early twentieth-century labor market, the postmaster job occupied a unique position. While not widespread in absolute numbers, it provided women with a well-compensated and flexible employment opportunity at a time when most skilled work remained highly restrictive. This opportunity, however, was not evenly distributed: it primarily benefited educated White women from high-status families. Literacy, prior business experience, and the political nature of the appointment process made the role more accessible to women with social and educational advantages. Thus, while the postmaster position offers valuable insight into women's labor force participation during this era, it largely reflects the experiences of those best positioned to take advantage of such opportunities.

2.3 Job Search Model On Postmasters and Women's Employment

How would a flexible, well-paid, and socially acceptable occupation like the postmaster position affect women's employment? I use a simple job search framework to illustrate that access to the postmaster position would likely increase women's labor force participation; however, some women may exit the labor force once their appointments end.[11] In the job search model, a

[8] Appendix Figure A1 shows that the share of women in the postmaster occupations in rural areas was much higher than the one in urban areas.

[9] Author's calculation based on the 1940 complete count census.

[10] Appendix Figure A2 provides a few examples of such flexible work arrangements.

[11] The job search framework can also be applied to men, but the predicted effects are minimal. The availability of postmaster jobs would have little impact on men's labor force participation, because men generally faced few social

woman who is not working receives a random wage offer of w in each period. She could either accept the offer and earn wage w, or reject the offer and be unemployed with a utility U. Let $V(w^*)$ denote the value of accepting a job with wage w. The reservation wage w^* is defined by:

$$V(w^*) = U,$$

so that the woman accepts any offer with $w \geq w^*$.

Because the postmaster position typically paid more than other skilled occupations available to women at the time, access to such a job increased the probability that women received an acceptable wage offer exceeding their reservation wage w^*, therefore increasing these women's labor force participation. Conversely, when the appointment ended, women's continued employment depended on whether comparable job offers remained available. If the wage of alternative employment did not meet or exceed w^*, some women optimally chose to exit the labor force rather than accept lower-wage work.

In addition, w can be interpreted as the overall value of a job, consisting of both the monetary wage and non-pecuniary components such as flexibility, social acceptability, and working conditions. In the historical United States, women's work decisions were shaped not only by wages but also by prevailing social norms. Marriage bars and expectations discouraging married women's market work reduced the utility of employment relative to non-employment. By increasing the attractiveness of not working, these forces effectively raised the reservation threshold w^*, which can be interpreted as the minimum acceptable job value or "reservation quality", and further reduced the probability that women would accept lower-paying or less desirable jobs after their postmaster appointments ended.

The job search model has several implications. First, the availability of "nice" jobs (Goldin, 2006)—positions similar to postmasters that are well paid, flexible, and socially acceptable—should increase labor force participation among women from relatively advantaged backgrounds. Second, continued labor force participation after postmaster appointments depends critically on the availability of alternative jobs offering comparable wages or quality, which are typically found in skilled occupations. When such jobs are scarce, women are more likely to exit the labor force rather than transition into lower-quality work. For women who do continue to be employed, the

or institutional barriers to employment.

model predicts that their post-appointment jobs will generally be full-time and offer wages comparable to those of postmaster positions. Finally, the model predicts heterogeneous responses across women based on factors that shape their reservation job value, such as socioeconomic background. Women from higher socioeconomic backgrounds tend to have higher reservation thresholds and, as a result, are less likely to accept available employment opportunities.

3 Data and Census Linking

3.1 Presidential Transitions

A presidential transition is defined as a change in the party of the president. In the early twentieth century, the United States experienced three such transitions. The first occurred in 1913, when Democrat Woodrow Wilson succeeded Republican William Howard Taft, ending nearly two decades of Republican control that began with William McKinley's election in 1896. The second transition followed in 1921, when Republican Warren Harding took office after Wilson's two terms. The third transition took place in 1933, when Democrat Franklin Roosevelt was elected amid the Great Depression. Because of Roosevelt's popularity, the next presidential transition did not occur until the early 1950s.

3.2 Postmaster Appointments

I collect a novel dataset on postmaster appointments during the early twentieth century in the United States. This is part of a larger archival dataset, "Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832–1971", which contains more than a century-long list of postmaster appointments for all post offices that ever existed (National Archives and Records Administration, 1977, Ancestry, 2021). To my knowledge, this paper is among the first to use these newly digitized post office appointment records to study U.S. postmasters. The dataset provides rich information about postmaster appointments, including postmaster names, appointment dates, and post office locations. Figure 1 shows a sample image of the archival dataset, which contains the postmaster appointment records for the Clermont post office in Lake County, Florida. The top of each appointment record indicates the name and location of the post offices. The table below displays postmaster names and appointment dates.

Based on post office locations, I infer the county and state of residence of postmasters. Because the Civil Service Commission required the candidates for postmasters to reside in the post office's delivery zone (United States Civil Service Commission, 1916), the county and state of appointment serve as reliable proxies for their place of residence.

Based on postmaster names, I infer the gender of postmasters. The first two postmasters appointed in the Clermont post office were most likely to be women, as indicated by predominantly female names such as "Isabelle" and "Florence," as well as the prefixes "Miss" and "Mrs." before their names. On the other hand, the last person appointed at the Clermont post office, Robert O. Seaver, was most likely to be a man. More rigorously, I used the method developed by Blevins and Mullen, 2015, which estimates the probability that an individual is female based on historical baby-name frequencies from the Social Security Administration. Additionally, for women postmasters, marital status is inferred from name prefixes: "Miss" would indicate a person had never been married at the time of the appointment, and "Mrs." would indicate a person was married or had been married at the time of the appointment. The resulting gender composition of the postmaster occupation is summarized in Figure 2. The left column shows a steady increase in the share of women postmasters between 1910 and 1940, although women remained underrepresented relative to other skilled occupations. The right column reports the share of ever-married women among postmasters, clerical workers, stenographers, and teachers. Approximately 80% of women postmasters had been married, substantially higher than the 10–30% observed in the comparison occupations. This pattern supports the argument in Section 2.2 that the postmaster position posed fewer barriers to entry for married women.

Based on postmaster appointment dates, I infer the political affiliation of postmasters. Given that postmasters were presidential appointees, they typically shared the party affiliation of the appointing president. The first postmaster appointed at the Clermont post office, Miss Isabelle H. Boyd, was appointed in 1931 under a Republican presidency, which means she was most likely a Republican. On the other hand, the second postmaster, Mrs. Florence M. Bowman, was appointed in 1935 under a Democratic presidency, indicating that she was most likely a Democrat. In particular, I calculate the distance between initial appointment dates and presidential transition dates for each postmaster. This allows me to identify postmasters appointed just before and after a presidential transition. Using the data on postmaster appointment dates, I plot the number of new postmasters coming into the office each year in Figure 3. The figure marks every presidential transition in the early twentieth century with a vertical dashed line, and it shows that the number of new postmasters increased sharply in the four years following each transition, while remaining relatively stable in other years. This indicates postmasters appointed before a presidential transition were replaced soon after by individuals from the incoming president's party,[12] corroborating the historical account outlined in Section 2.1.

3.3 Linked Census Data

To obtain pre-appointment and post-appointment characteristics of postmasters, I link those appointed between 1920 and 1940 separately to the complete-count 1920 and 1940 decennial census records (Ruggles et al., 2021). Since the only available information for linking is postmaster names, postmaster appointment dates, and post office locations, I impose a conservative linking criterion requiring an exact and unique match of first name, last name, and county and state of residence.[13] For women in particular, I drop matches where the prefixes (in the appointment data) and marital status (in the census data) contradict each other.

To address the challenge of linking women who may have changed their names due to marriage, I begin by identifying those who likely experienced a change in marital status between their postmaster appointment and the census year. Because any name changes due to marriage needed to be reported, the person's maiden name and marital name would each appear as separate entries in the appointment data. In such cases, I drop the appointments with maiden names (and keep the appointments with married names) when linking forward to the 1940 census, and I drop the appointments with married names (and keep the appointments with maiden names) when linking backward to the 1920 census.

The linking rate for women is approximately 39%. As shown in Appendix Section 12.3, the main reason for failed matches is the absence of a unique match, often due to common names. Linking rates also vary modestly across subgroups: married women are slightly more likely to be linked than unmarried women, with differences ranging from 2.7 to 3.6 pp., while the urban–rural gap is even smaller, at less than 1 pp. To address non-representativeness of the linked

[12] Blevins, 2021 shows the same pattern for postmasters appointed during the late nineteenth century, as presented in Figure A3 in the Appendix. Mastrorocco and Teso, 2023 establishes similar stylized facts for other federal employees employed outside of the Department of Post Office between 1817 and 1905.

[13] Appendix Section 12.3 reports linking rates under alternative specifications, including exact versus fuzzy name matching and state-only versus county-and-state matching.

sample, I apply inverse probability weights following Bailey et al., 2020, which reweigh the observations to balance the observed characteristics of the linked sample with those of the full population of postmasters. The weights depend on variables such as post office classification, postmaster appointment year, frequency of names, and whether the name has a prefix. While I recognize that the inverse probability weights approach is not perfect, I demonstrate in Appendix Section 12.4 that the linked sample of postmasters closely resembles the census sample of postmasters, providing reassurance about the validity of the linking procedure.

3.4 Census Tree Linked Sample

To obtain a panel of women postmasters and their women neighbors, I combine the linked census data with the Census Tree data. The Census Tree data links individuals between censuses by relying on user-contributed links from FamilySearch.org, a genealogy platform where users find their ancestors using historical records (Price et al., 2021; Buckles et al., 2023). This approach overcomes a major challenge in historical census data linkage—tracking women who often changed their names after marriage—and represents a substantial improvement in the ability to follow women longitudinally.

In the Census Tree linked sample, women postmasters were first linked to the 1920 census following the procedure outlined in Section 3.3. Then, I rely on the Census Tree data to link both women postmasters and their 1920 women neighbors forward to the 1940 census. Since individuals are linked twice, the census tree linked sample has a smaller number of postmasters.

4 Descriptive Statistics of Women Postmasters

To understand the selection of women postmasters, I compare their predetermined characteristics with those of the general female population aged between 18 and 65 in the 1920 and 1940 complete-count censuses (Ruggles et al., 2021). First, women postmasters were selected from predominantly White, native-born, and rural populations. As shown in Table 1, 99% of women postmasters were White and 98% were native-born, which is unsurprising given that only citizens were eligible for appointment. While 57% of women in the general population lived in urban areas in 1920, only 11% of women postmasters did. This pattern reflects both the geographic distribution of post offices and the tendency to appoint women to smaller, lower-paid rural post offices. Despite their rural overrepresentation, women postmasters appear to have come from relatively advantaged households. They were slightly less likely than other women to live on farms and more likely to own their homes, consistent with higher socioeconomic status. Family size also differed modestly: women postmasters had an average of 1.7 children in 1920, compared with 2.1 among women in the general population.

In addition, women postmasters were highly qualified relative to the general female population. On average, they had 11.7 years of schooling, substantially more than the 9-year average among all women. Despite this educational advantage, most women postmasters were not engaged in paid labor prior to their appointment: in 1920, only 32.5% reported a gainful occupation.[14] Nevertheless, they were more likely to be employed than women in the general population, among whom only 25.6% participated in paid labor, indicating positive selection on work experience. Beyond formal employment, women postmasters also appear positively selected on business experience. 5.4% were self-employed in 1920, slightly higher than the 3.7% self-employed women in the general population. Conditional on marriage, 47.3% had a self-employed husband, suggesting that many likely accumulated relevant experience through unpaid work in family businesses. These patterns point to the distinctive role of women postmasters within their communities: although many lacked prior formal employment, their relatively high education and exposure to business activities likely endowed them with the skills necessary to manage post offices effectively.

I also compare women postmasters with their 1920 women neighbors to assess selection relative to a more locally comparable group. Following Logan and Parman, 2017, I identify neighbors based on census enumeration order: because enumerators typically recorded households in the order they encountered them while moving along a street, the sequence of entries in the census reflects physical proximity. As a result, I consider households recorded on the same page of the microfilm as neighbors.[15] Comparison between Columns 1 and 3 of Table 1 suggest that relative to the general female population, women postmasters more closely resemble their women neighbors. Both groups were drawn from predominantly White, native-born, and rural populations: 96% of women neighbors were White, 91% were native-born, and 74% lived in rural

[14] Census instructions defined occupations as work "by which the person enumerated earns money or a money equivalent." See https://usa.ipums.org/usa/voliii/inst1920.shtml.

[15] A limitation of this method is that it does not capture households located across the street from one another, as they may not appear consecutively in the enumeration.

areas. Educational differences are also much smaller in this comparison, with women neighbors completing an average of 10.1 years of schooling.

5 Empirical Strategy

5.1 Regression Discontinuity

Taking advantage of the fact that postmasters were presidential appointees and were rarely re-appointed after the party of the president changed, I use an RD design to compare the 1940 outcomes for postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition, when Franklin Roosevelt (Democrat) replaced Herbert Hoover (Republican). Those appointed just before the transition were unlikely to be reappointed due to their political affiliations, whereas those appointed just after could expect future reappointments under a Democratic administration that remained in power for the next twenty years. Because all individuals in this comparison self-selected into postmaster positions, the RD design helps account for many unobserved factors associated with this selection. Formally, the RD treatment effect is the following:

$$E[Y_i(1) - Y_i(0)|X_i = X_0],$$

where the treatment is being a postmaster in 1940, Y_i is the economic outcome for individual i in 1940, X_0 is the day that the presidential transition took place (March 4, 1933), and X_i is the initial appointment date. The running variable is the difference between the initial appointment date and the presidential transition date. The specification also includes individual-level controls such as age and age squared, marital status, farm and urban residence, years of education, and whether the individual migrated in the past five years.

I use both sharp RD and fuzzy RD designs. The sharp RD design assumes the presidential transition determines one's postmaster status perfectly: those appointed just before the transition are treated, and those appointed just after are not. The fuzzy RD design, by contrast, allows for some exceptions to this rule and accounts for cases where the transition does not perfectly determine postmaster status. Conceptually, the fuzzy RD is analogous to an Instrumental Variables (IV) approach, estimating a first-stage regression of reporting postmaster occupation in 1940 on the running variable. Both RD designs are implemented using standard local polynomial methods, with robust bias-corrected confidence intervals and data-driven optimal bandwidth selection, as recommended in the literature (Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik, 2014; Calonico, Cattaneo, and Farrell, 2018; Calonico, Cattaneo, Farrell, and Titiunik, 2019; Calonico, Cattaneo, and Farrell, 2020).

5.1.1 Discontinuity in Postmaster Probability at the 1933 Transition

To motivate the RD design, it is important to establish that the probability of holding a postmaster position in 1940 changes discontinuously around the 1933 presidential transition. The top two figures of Figure 4 illustrate this first-stage relationship, with the outcome measured by a dummy variable equal to 1 if the individual reported their occupation as postmaster in the 1940 census. The non-parametric figures plot the linked census data using quantile-spaced bins of the standardized running variable (Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik, 2015), with roughly 40 observations per bin. Following Korting et al., 2023, no fitted lines are included to avoid misleading interpretations of the discontinuity.

Individuals appointed just before and after the transition exhibit markedly different probabilities of being a postmaster in 1940. Those appointed just before the 1933 presidential transition (bins to the left of the vertical line) rarely reported postmaster as their occupation in 1940, reflecting the lack of reappointment due to their political affiliations. In contrast, those appointed just after the transition (bins to the right) largely remained postmasters, as they could be reappointed for multiple terms. Column 1 of Table 3 reports that the RD estimate of this discontinuity is 34 pp. for women and 53 pp. for men. Note that the probability of being a postmaster in 1940 does not change perfectly from 0 to 1 at the presidential transition. This likely reflects that some individuals appointed just before the transition still reported their occupation as postmaster in the census, while some appointed just after had already left the position or reported a different occupation in the census.

5.1.2 No Discontinuities in Predetermined Variables at the 1933 Transition

To support the validity of the RD design, I demonstrate that individuals appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition were similar across a range of predetermined characteristics. This similarity mitigates concerns that postmasters on either side of the cutoff were selected according to systematically different criteria. For example, one potential concern is that Franklin Roosevelt, the incoming Democratic president, may have targeted appointments in counties that previously supported Republican candidates. Reassuringly, this is not reflected in the data: Table 2 shows a small and statistically insignificant RD estimate for the 1928 Republican vote share,[16] and Figure A4 in the Appendix reveals no discontinuity at the transition, implying that post-transition appointees were no more likely to come from Republican-leaning counties than pre-transition appointees. There is also little evidence that the severity of the Great Depression shaped appointment patterns around the transition. In particular, the county-level changes in per capita retail sales between 1929 and 1933 (a measure of Depression severity used in Fishback, Horrace, et al., 2005; Feigenbaum, 2015) does not change discontinuously at the presidential transition.

Additionally, I find no evidence of differential linkage rates to the census among those appointed just before and after the transition, alleviating concerns that the outcome differences are driven by selection in the linking process, such as through migration. Moreover, women appointed just before and just after the transition appear similar across a range of individual characteristics. They have comparable socioeconomic backgrounds, measured by their fathers' average occupational score rank, as well as similar levels of education, marital status, and employment. Together, these findings provide strong support for the comparability of the treatment and control groups in the RD design.

5.2 Difference-in-Differences

In addition to the RD design, I also implement a DID design that compares women who had been postmasters with their 1920 women neighbors who had never held the position. This approach examines whether women postmasters experienced better labor market outcomes than their women neighbors who lacked postmaster work experience. By comparing women within the same neighborhoods, the DID design controls for neighborhood-level characteristics as well as endogenous sorting across locations. The specification is the following:

$$Y_{ihet} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 PM_i + \alpha_2 Post_t + \alpha_3 PM_i \times Post_t + \gamma_h + \gamma_e + X'_{ihet}\Theta + \epsilon_{ihet}$$

[16] Voting data from 1928 is obtained from ICPSR Study 8611: Electoral Data for Counties in the United States (Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research, 1984).

Y_{ihet} is the outcome variable for person i who had education level e and lived in neighborhood h in year t. t only takes on two values — 1920 and 1940. PM_i is a dummy variable that equals 1 if the person had been a postmaster. $Post_t$ is a dummy variable that equals 1 if the year is 1940. The specification includes neighborhood fixed effects γ_h and education fixed effects γ_e, allowing comparisons within neighborhoods and across women with similar educational attainment. I also added individual-level control variables X_{ihet}, such as age and age squared, marital status, and farm and urban status. The data used here are the census tree linked sample of native-born White women aged between 18 and 65 who lived in neighborhoods with at least one postmaster.

6 RD Results

6.1 Decline in Women's Employment and Labor Supply

The primary outcome variable of interest is whether an individual was employed in 1940, defined as reporting a gainful occupation in the 1940 Census. As shown in the left column of Figure 4, approximately 40% to 60% of women postmasters appointed just before the presidential transition were employed in 1940, three to four years after their appointment terms ended. This employment rate is considerably lower than that of women postmasters appointed just after the transition. Among the latter group, most of whom were still serving as postmasters in 1940, roughly 80% to 90% were employed that year. The sharp RD estimate in Column 2 of Panel A in Table 3 indicates a 24 pp. difference in the probability of employment between these two groups. Additionally, women also experienced a large decline in their labor supply. For women postmasters appointed just before the presidential transition, they worked approximately 20 to 30 weeks per year, while those appointed just after worked approximately 40 to 50 weeks per year. The sharp RD estimates in Columns 3 and 4 of Panel A in Table 3 indicate a difference of 17 weeks per year and 11 hours per week in labor supply. Table 3 also reports fuzzy RD results, which compare two groups of "compliers": individuals appointed before the presidential transition and did not report postmaster as their 1940 occupation, and individuals appointed after and reported postmaster as their 1940 occupation. The fuzzy RD estimates are much larger, indicating that the gap in the probability of employment for these two groups was 64 pp., and the gap in labor supply was 44 weeks worked per year and 28 hours worked per week.

Both the sharp and fuzzy RD estimates suggest that women experienced a large decline in employment and labor supply after their postmaster appointments ended. Could this decline reflect a shift from formal labor market participation to other types of work, such as self-employment or unpaid family work? The evidence, however, suggests this is not the case. Columns 5 and 6 of Table 3 show that women whose appointments had ended were not more likely to be self-employed or working as unpaid family workers in 1940.[17]

Nevertheless, some women remained employed in 1940 by transitioning into other occupations. Table 4 summarizes the most common jobs held in 1940 by women appointed before the 1933 presidential transition who reported a valid occupation other than postmaster. Many of these women moved into skilled or white-collar jobs: among those still employed, Column 1 shows that 11.8% were clerical workers, 9.2% were managers of small businesses, 5.8% were bookkeepers, and 5.7% were teachers in 1940. This pattern implies that the skills acquired as postmasters (such as accounting and record-keeping) were highly transferable, enabling these women to successfully transition into a range of other white-collar professions. Moreover, Columns 2 and 3 suggest the types of jobs held did not vary much between urban and rural areas, indicating that some women were able to access white-collar opportunities even in rural areas. Similarly, differences in occupational distribution by marital status were modest (Columns 4 and 5), although far fewer married women were still employed in 1940.

To quantify how much of the decline in employment was mitigated by switching to other skilled occupations, I conduct a simple decomposition. First, I estimate the *mechanical effect* by setting all outcomes to zero for individuals who did not report postmaster as their occupation in 1940. This captures the total decline in employment assuming women did not find any replacement work. Next, I estimate the *substitution effect* by setting outcomes to zero for individuals who did not report either the postmaster occupation or another skilled occupation,[18] thereby capturing the portion of the decline not offset by switching to other skilled occupations. As shown in Panel A of Appendix Table A1, the mechanical effect on employment is 34.2 pp. and the substitution effect is 22.5 pp., suggesting that 65.8% (22.5/34.2) of the mechanical employ-

[17] The 1940 census instructions (item 539) specify that unpaid family workers include those who work "in a shop or store from which the family obtained its support, or on other work that contributed to the family income (not including home housework or incidental chores).": https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/decennial-census/technical-documentation/questionnaires/1940/1940-instructions.html. Alternatively, all family members in a household where the head is self-employed can be considered as family workers because many business owners rely on family members as laborers (Chiswick and Robinson, 2021).

[18] Skilled occupations are defined as those with occ1950 codes between 0 and 490, excluding 100 and 123 (i.e., farmers).

ment loss is not accounted by switching to other skilled occupations. Instead, this substantial share reflects exits from the labor force. Results for labor supply are similar: 68% (13.16/19.30) of the decline in weeks worked per year is not recovered through substitution.

6.2 Gender Differences in Employment

As shown in Section 5.1.1, the probability of being a postmaster changes discontinuously at the presidential transition date for both women and men. Like women, male postmasters appointed just before the presidential transition could not be reappointed. However, their subsequent labor market outcomes were markedly different. The right column of Figure 4 shows that male postmasters who could not be reappointed as postmasters experienced a very small reduction in their 1940 employment and labor supply, suggesting that most were able to transition into other jobs after their appointments ended. Columns 2 and 3 of Panels B and C in Table 3 confirm that the RD estimate for men is small and statistically insignificant, while gender differences in employment and labor supply remain large and significant.[19] This contrast indicates that the sharp decline in women's employment is unlikely to reflect selection on political affiliation, since men and women shared the same appointment conditions.

Conditional on new employment, men also often transitioned into other skilled positions after losing their postmaster appointments: 23.3% became managers, 11.4% farm owners, 5.8% clerical workers, and 4.7% salesmen, as shown in Table A2 in the appendix. The similarity in post-appointment job categories for men and women suggests that postmaster positions endowed both groups with transferable skills that facilitated employment in other skilled occupations. Nevertheless, applying the same decomposition to men (Panel B of Table A1) reveals a stark contrast in outcomes. Although the mechanical employment effect is larger for men (53.3 pp.) than for women, implying that men would face a substantial employment loss if no one found replacement work, the substitution effect for men is much smaller (12.3 pp.). In other words, only 23.3% (12.3/53.3) of the mechanical employment loss remains unexplained by transitions into other skilled occupations.[20] These patterns highlight that men faced fewer constraints in accessing alternative labor market opportunities than women.

[19] This gender-based comparison parallels the "difference in discontinuity" estimates used to address selection bias as shown in Grembi et al., 2016, with gender replacing the usual cross-sectional comparison.

[20] Because there is no RD effect on men's overall employment, this remaining 23.3% of the mechanical loss is likely accounted for by transitions into non-skilled occupations.

6.3 Robustness Checks

The baseline RD results are robust to a range of alternative specifications, as shown in Table A3 in the appendix. These include (1) bias-corrected RD estimates, (2) estimates with an Epanechnikov kernel density, (3) estimates with a fixed bandwidth choice of 1,000 days, (4) specifications that control for county-level controls such as the share of high school/college graduates, the share of women, the share of Whites, the share of the working population by gender, and population density, and (5) estimates with age groups fixed effects where age groups are defined as below 30, between 30 and 40 ... between 60 and 70, and above 70 years old. Across all these specifications, the estimated effects remain consistent in sign and magnitude, reinforcing the baseline findings.

I also conduct two additional robustness checks. First, I conduct a placebo test using a pseudo–presidential transition date (March 4, 1926), which yields null effects across all outcome variables. Second, I implement a donut RD specification (Barreca et al., 2011) that excludes postmasters appointed between the 1932 election (November 8, 1932) and the actual presidential transition (March 4, 1933). This approach tests whether the baseline results are driven by potentially endogenous appointments during this period, when appointees may have anticipated the incoming administration. As shown in Panel G of Table A3, the donut RD estimates for employment and labor supply are only slightly smaller than the main results in Table 3, suggesting that the findings are not driven by individuals appointed immediately before the transition.

7 DID Results

Using the Census Tree linked sample and a DID design, I examine whether women with postmaster work experience had better 1940 employment outcomes than their 1920 women neighbors.[21] Conditional on sorting into the same neighborhood, this comparison primarily reflects within-group variation among educated, White, and high-status women, rather than differences across the broader female population. A key assumption of the DID design is that the outcomes of neighboring women are not affected by the postmaster appointments. As shown in the right column of Figure 5, this assumption is supported by the fact that these women neighbors did not

[21] Employment is the only outcome available here since information related to labor supply is not available in years before 1940 and thus could not be examined in a DID design.

become postmasters themselves in 1940, and their employment and labor supply trends appear smooth and unaffected by the timing of the postmaster appointment or the presidential transition. In particular, fewer than 20% of them were employed in 1940, and their average annual weeks worked was under 10 weeks.

The DID results with education and neighborhood fixed effects are presented in Table 5. To ensure that the DID results are not sensitive to the appointment timing of women postmasters, the table shows the results by different samples of women postmasters appointed within 1400 days (approximately 4 years), 1600, 1800,..., 2400 days (approximately 6 to 7 years) of the 1933 presidential transition. For women appointed before the presidential transition (Panel A), the coefficients of the postmaster dummy variables are consistently positive and significant across all columns, which shows that women postmasters were positively selected and were more likely to be employed during the pre-treatment period than their 1920 women neighbors, consistent with the descriptive statistics shown in Table 1. However, the DID estimates are negative but not statistically different from zero, suggesting that former women postmasters were not more likely to be employed in 1940 relative to their 1920 women neighbors. On the other hand, women appointed after the transition were 55 to 58 pp. more likely to be employed than their women neighbors (Panel B) because the postmaster appointments boosted women's labor force participation significantly. To strengthen the credibility of the results, I show in Appendix Table A4 that the DID estimates are robust to three alternative neighbor definitions: women on nearby census pages, women residing in the same county, and skilled women in the same county in 1920.

Combined with the RD results, the DID results suggest that although some women were able to transition into other skilled occupations after their postmaster appointments ended, their average employment rate was no higher than that of their similarly high-status women neighbors. This pattern indicates that postmaster experience itself did not provide a lasting employment advantage for women.

8 Mechanisms

Why did many women exit the labor force after their postmaster appointments? Women postmasters represented a distinctive segment of the labor force—well educated, White, and likely to have high reservation wages, so their primary constraint was the limited availability of jobs similar to the postmaster position. To support this interpretation, I first show that women who remained employed mainly held full-time positions and, in many cases, earned wages comparable to postmaster salaries, consistent with the reservation-wage mechanism outlined in the job search model in Section 2.3. I then examine heterogeneity in continued employment, highlighting the roles of individual-level characteristics, such as socioeconomic background, and institutional factors, including state-level marriage bars and severity of the Great Depression.

8.1 Reservation-Wage Interpretation

I begin by testing the reservation-wage interpretation using the same RD strategy on additional occupational outcomes that characterize both work intensity (full-time versus part-time) and wage levels. Columns 1 to 3 of Table 6 report RD estimates for three occupational outcomes: (1) employment in a full-time occupation, defined as at least 40 weeks per year and 35 hours per week; (2) employment in a skilled occupation, including managerial, clerical, sales, and operative positions; and (3) employment in a part-time occupation, defined as positive weeks worked below 25 and positive hours worked below 20. Columns 4 to 6 then examine wage outcomes in 1940 along three dimensions: (4) the probability of earning positive wages (the extensive margin); (5) total wages including zeros, which capture overall earnings losses due to both reduced wages and employment exits (the intensive margin); and (6) the natural logarithm of wages excluding zeros, which measures earnings conditional on employment. Together, these outcomes allow me to evaluate whether women who transitioned to new jobs after losing their postmaster appointments earned wages comparable to those who remained postmasters.

For work-intensity outcomes, the RD estimates for full-time and skilled employment are 21.7 and 27.7 pp., comparable in magnitude to the estimated effect on gainful employment (23.9 pp.), while the estimate for part-time employment is small and statistically insignificant. These results suggest that the decline in women's post-appointment employment is largely driven by exits from full-time and skilled occupations, rather than by transitions into part-time or lower-intensity work.[22] For wage outcomes, women who were not reappointed as postmasters were 32 pp. less likely to earn positive wages in 1940 than those who remained postmasters, and the

[22] Beyond the RD results, Table A5 shows that the labor supply in postmaster jobs and the "other" jobs women held in 1940 after losing their appointments was highly comparable. Women in both groups worked on average 44 weeks per year and 39-40 hours per week, with identical medians of 52 weeks and similar median weekly hours. This indicates that women who remained employed were primarily in full-time jobs with time demands similar to those of postmaster positions.

average wage difference (including zeros) between the two groups was $753 in 1940 dollars. In contrast, the RD estimate for log wages (excluding zeros) is statistically insignificant, indicating that conditional on re-employment, women who found new jobs earned wages that were statistically indistinguishable from those of women who continued as postmasters. Overall, these findings are consistent with a reservation-wage mechanism in which women exited the labor force when alternative full-time and skilled jobs were unavailable, while those who remained employed earned wages comparable to postmaster salaries.

8.2 Heterogeneity in Continued Employment

I next examine heterogeneity in the RD estimates by individual- and institutional-level factors that affect reservation wages and the availability of alternative employment opportunities. I begin with an individual-level characteristic: women's own socioeconomic background. Women from higher socioeconomic backgrounds likely have higher reservation wages, making them more likely to exit the labor force after losing the postmaster appointments. To test this, I proxy women's socioeconomic background using first names following Olivetti and Paserman, 2015 and estimate RD effects separately for women from high versus low socioeconomic backgrounds.[23] Here, a larger positive RD estimate reflects a greater drop in employment and labor supply among those appointed just before the presidential transition, indicating a more negative effect. Panels A and B of Table 7 show that women from higher socioeconomic backgrounds experienced larger reductions in employment (50 pp.) and labor supply (28 weeks worked per year and 21 hours worked per week), while women from lower socioeconomic backgrounds experienced smaller and statistically insignificant declines in these outcomes. Although the differences between the estimates for high- and low-socioeconomic-status women are not statistically significant, the direction of the effects is consistent with a reservation-wage interpretation.[24]

Beyond individual characteristics, institutional barriers may have limited women's employment opportunities. During this period, 26 states introduced legislation aimed at restricting the

[23] Specifically, for each first name j held by daughters aged 5 to 15 in the 1900 census, I compute the average occupational rank of their fathers, F_j. Given that women postmasters were already positively selected on socioeconomic status, I classify a woman as coming from a high socioeconomic background if her associated F_j is above the 75th percentile of the distribution.

[24] Table A6 presents similar evidence by educational attainment: women postmasters with a high school education experienced larger employment declines. This is also consistent with a reservation-wage interpretation since more educated women may have had higher reservation wages.

employment of married women (Shallcross, 1940; Scharf, 1980; see Figure 6), thereby reducing the availability of acceptable jobs for women.[25] In Panels C and D, I estimate the RD effects separately for women living in states that did and did not introduce legislation restricting married women's employment. Among women living in states with introduced marriage bars, they experienced large and statistically significant declines in employment (by 32 pp.) and labor supply (by 19 weeks worked per year and 13 hours worked per week). In contrast, women living in states without such legislation exhibit much smaller and statistically insignificant changes in employment outcomes. This comparison suggests that state-level discrimination limited women's alternative employment opportunities and may help explain why many women exited the labor force after their postmaster appointments.

Additionally, local economic conditions during the Great Depression likely contributed to the reduction in women's employment. In Panels E and F, I estimate RD effects separately for women living in counties that experienced above- versus below-median levels of the economic downturn. Because county-level unemployment data are largely unavailable for this period, I follow Fishback, Horrace, et al., 2005 and Feigenbaum, 2015 in using changes in retail sales per capita between 1929 and 1933 as a proxy for the severity of the downturn, with data drawn from Fishback and Kantor, 2018.[26] I find that women living in areas that experienced a more severe economic downturn experienced a 40 pp. reduction in the probability of employment in 1940 and decreased their labor supply by 22.6 weeks per year. By contrast, RD estimates for women in counties with less severe declines are small and statistically insignificant. These patterns suggest that in areas most affected by the Depression, job opportunities that met women's reservation wages were particularly scarce. In line with the predictions of the job search model, many women in these counties may have chosen to exit the labor force. The results also align with broader trends in women's labor force participation during the 1930s. While White married women's employment generally increased as households relied on additional income (Bellou and Cardia, 2021), former postmasters were in relatively privileged positions. For these women,

[25] Although these legislative efforts were often unsuccessful, they nevertheless signaled to employers that the hiring of married women was discouraged and may have deterred some women from seeking employment altogether (Shallcross, 1940). Additionally, a Gallup poll found that a majority of respondents supported state legislatures' efforts to restrict married women's right to work (Gallup, 1939), even though a government survey showed that most married women sought employment out of economic necessity (Brown, 1929).

[26] As shown in Figure A6, these losses varied considerably across counties, with the South generally less affected. Counties with larger urban and manufacturing sectors experienced steeper declines in retail sales, consistent with the city-level patterns documented by Feigenbaum, 2015.

continued employment was less an economic necessity and more constrained by the limited alternative employment opportunities.[27]

9 Conclusion

This paper examines whether a historically woman-friendly occupation—the U.S. postmaster position between 1920 and 1940—improved women's long-term labor market outcomes. Using newly digitized appointment records linked to complete-count census data, I show that postmaster jobs attracted educated and qualified White women into the labor market. Despite offering high pay and flexibility, these positions generated only short-lived gains: women who could not be reappointed due to the 1933 presidential transition experienced a large decline in employment, with only a few transitioning into other skilled occupations. The results are consistent with a reservation-wage mechanism, in which women remained employed only when comparable job opportunities were available.

These findings suggest that the benefits of woman-friendly occupations depended on the availability of comparable jobs; when such opportunities were scarce, even high-paying, flexible positions did little to sustain labor force participation. That said, it is worth noting that successful examples in later periods, such as the transformation of the pharmacy profession into a well-paid, family-friendly career (Goldin and Katz, 2016), do exist. Examining the types of features and policies that enhance women's labor market participation and narrow the gender wage gap in various contexts remains essential for advancing our understanding of gender equality in the labor market.

10 Data Availability

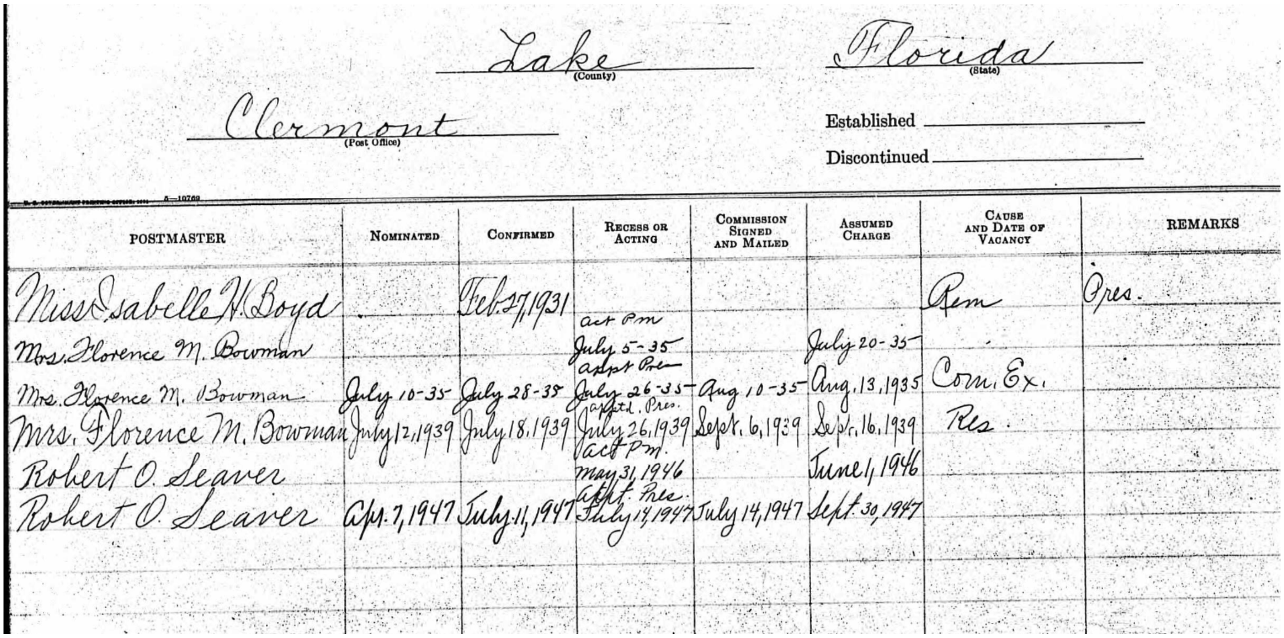
The data and replication package for this paper are available at

https://doi.org/10.3886/E249981V1 (Li, 2026).

[27]RD estimates for household outcomes in Section 12.5 further support the view that former women postmasters were not under substantial financial pressure to seek alternative employment. Husbands of women who lost their postmaster appointments did not earn more to make up the household earnings loss, and there are no meaningful differences in homeownership rates or house values between women who lost their appointments and those who could get reappointed.

11 Figures and Tables

Figure 1: Sample Image from "Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832-1971"



Lake (County) Florida (State)

Clermont (Post Office)

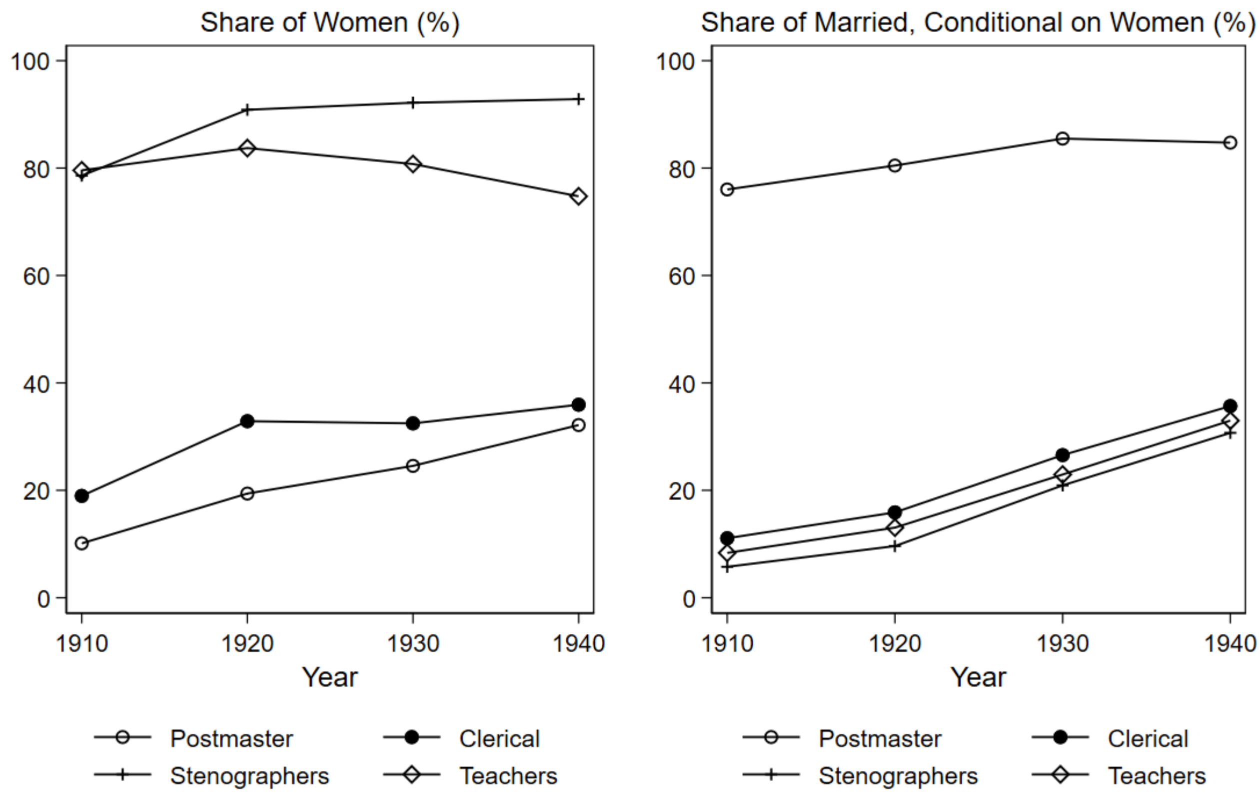
Established

Discontinued

POSTMASTER	NOMINATED	CONFIRMED	RECESS OR ACTING	COMMISSION SIGNED AND MAILED	ASSUMED CHARGE	CAUSE AND DATE OF VACANCY	REMARKS
Miss Isabelle H. Boyd		Feb. 27, 1931				Rem	Pres.
Mrs. Florence M. Bowman			act Pm July 5-35		July 20-35		
Mrs. Florence M. Bowman	July 10-35	July 28-35	appt Pres July 26-35	Aug 10-35	Aug. 13, 1935	Com. Ex.	
Mrs. Florence M. Bowman	July 12, 1939	July 18, 1939	appt. Pres. July 26, 1939	Sept. 6, 1939	Sept. 16, 1939	Res.	
Robert O. Seaver			act Pm. May 31, 1946		June 1, 1946		
Robert O. Seaver	Apr. 7, 1947	July 11, 1947	appt. Pres. July 14, 1947	July 14, 1947	Sept 30, 1947		

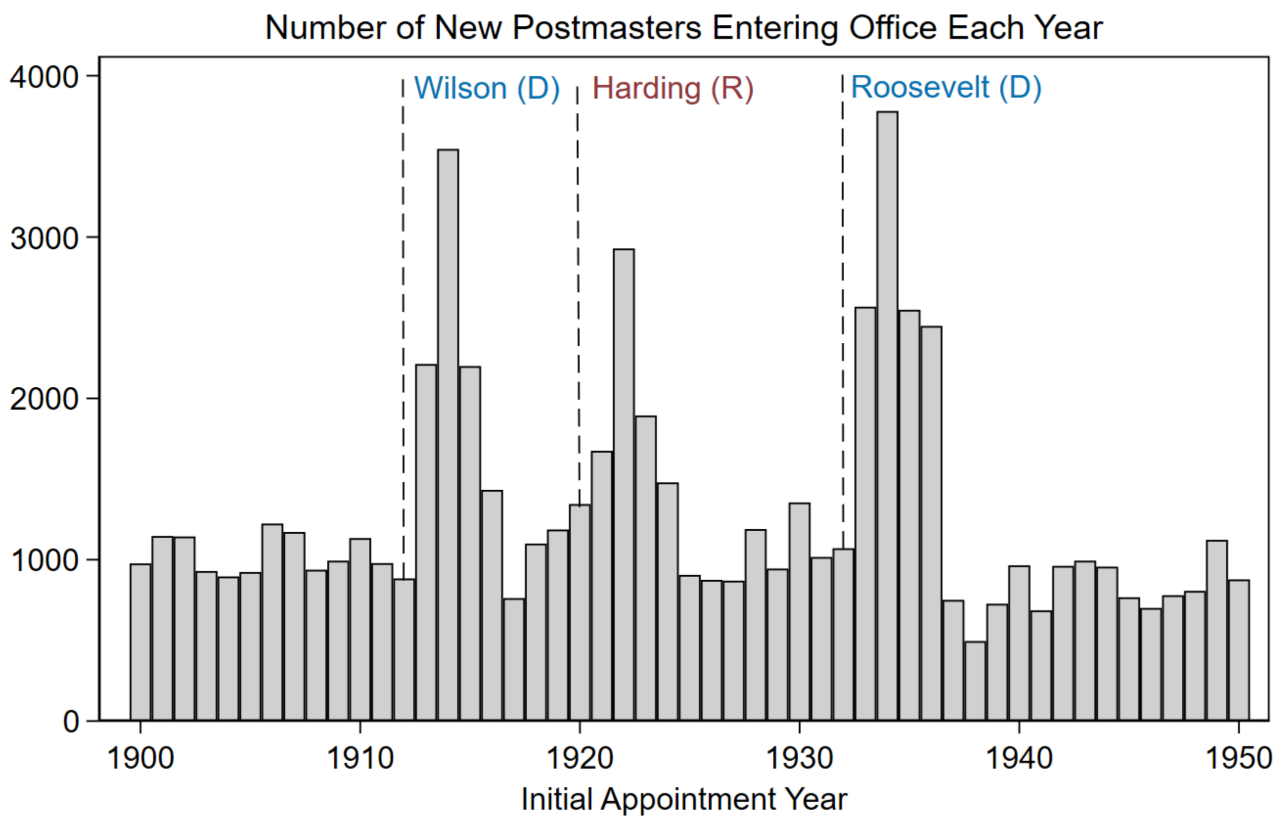
Source: Ancestry, 2021; National Archives and Records Administration, 1977. The sample image shows the dataset contains rich information about postmaster appointments, including post office locations, postmaster names and postmaster appointment dates.

Figure 2: Share of Women and Married Women Across Occupations



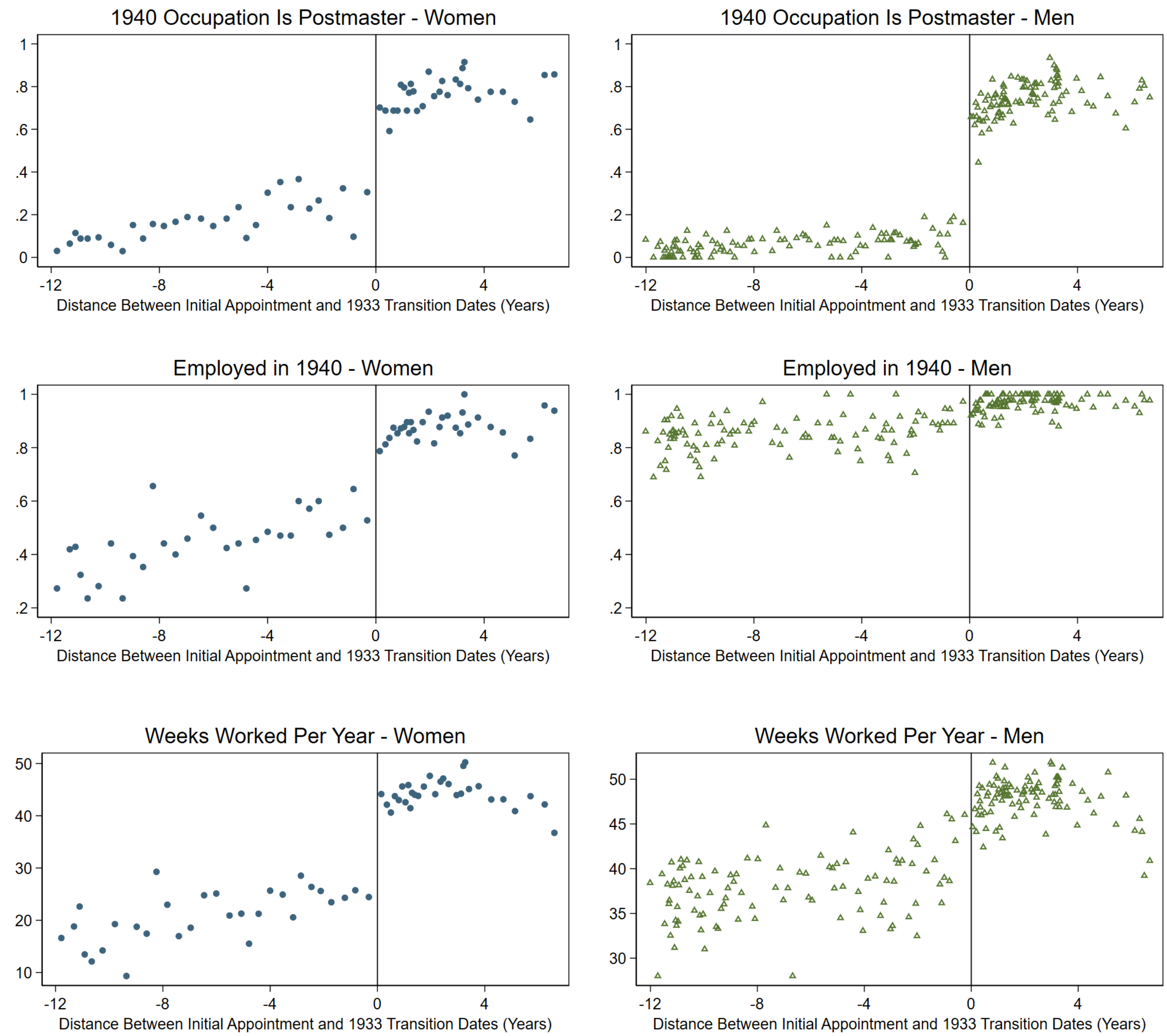
The left column displays the share of women employed as postmasters, clerical workers, stenographers, and teachers between 1910 and 1940. The right column displays the share of ever-married women among women employed in these occupations between 1910 and 1940. Data on postmasters are from the Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832–1971. Data on other occupations are from the 1% IPUMS census samples.

Figure 3: Number of New Postmasters Entering Office Each Year



The figure shows the number of new postmasters entering office each year. Each vertical dashed line indicates the election year that led to a presidential transition when the party of the president changed from Republican to Democrat or from Democrat to Republican. Changes in the presidency within the same party are not labeled. The author's calculation is based on the dataset "Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832-1971".

Figure 4: RD Results on 1940 Outcomes Between Postmasters Appointed Just Before and Just After the 1933 Presidential Transition - By Gender

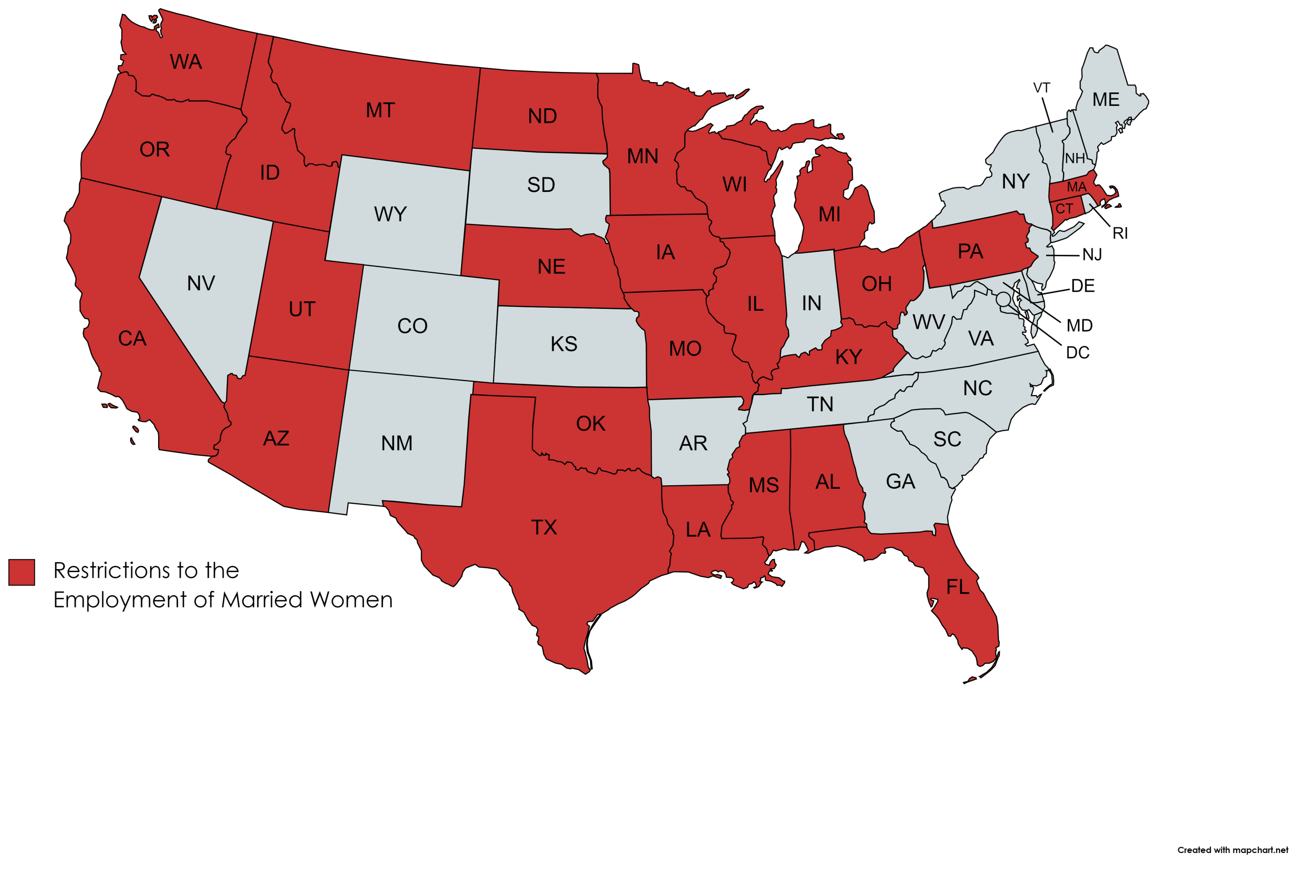


The figure shows RD Results between postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition for women (left column) and men (right column). The outcome variables are whether one reported postmaster being their occupation in 1940, whether they were employed in 1940, and the number of weeks worked per year in 1939. The sample is linked data between postmaster appointments and the 1940 complete-count census. The running variable is the standardized distance between the initial appointment and the 1933 presidential transition dates. Data are plotted in quantile-spaced bins, and each bin contains roughly 40 observations. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. The results in table form are shown in Table 3. Results for additional outcomes are shown in Figure A5.

Figure 5: 1940 Outcomes Between Women Postmasters and Their Women Neighbors

The figures are binned scatter plots of 1940 outcomes between women postmasters (left column) and their women neighbors (right column). The outcome variables are whether one reported postmaster being their occupation in 1940, whether they were employed in 1940, and the number of weeks worked per year in 1939. The sample is census tree linked data, which has a smaller number of observations and is different than the sample used in Figure 4. N(Women PM)=736 and N(Women Neighbors)=5,468. The running variable is the standardized distance between the initial appointment and the 1933 presidential transition dates. Data are plotted in quantile-spaced bins, and each bin contains roughly 40 observations. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights.

Figure 6: States that Introduced Legislation Against Married Women Working During the 1930s



Author's reproduction of Shallcross, 1940. The figure shows the states that introduced legislation against married women working during the Great Depression.

Table 1: Predetermined Characteristics of Women Postmasters and the General Population

	(1) Women PM	(2) Married Women PM	(3) Women Neighbors	(4) All Women
Variables Based on the 1920 Census				
Age	33.6	35.1	37.7	36.2
	(9.0)	(8.6)	(13.2)	(12.7)
White	99.1	98.7	96.4	89.9
	(9.3)	(11.1)	(18.5)	(30.1)
Native Born	98.2	98.2	91.2	82.4
	(13.2)	(13.3)	(28.4)	(38.0)
Urban	11.0	10.6	25.9	56.8
	(31.3)	(30.8)	(43.8)	(49.5)
Farm	22.1	22.3	18.1	24.6
	(41.5)	(41.7)	(38.5)	(43.0)
Married	70.3	-	67.8	68.5
	(45.7)	-	(46.7)	(46.5)
Employed	32.5	15.2	22.0	25.6
	(46.8)	(35.9)	(41.4)	(43.7)
Self-Employed	5.4	2.1	2.9	3.7
	(22.6)	(14.3)	(16.7)	(18.8)
Employed (H)	-	97.3	-	-
	-	(16.2)	-	-
Self-Employed (H)	-	47.3	-	-
	-	(50.0)	-	-
N	1921	1106	159051	30129809
Conditional on Head/Spouse				
Homeowner	66.4	66.9	57.9	44.2
	(47.3)	(47.1)	(49.4)	(49.7)
# Children	1.7	1.8	1.8	2.1
	(1.6)	(1.6)	(1.8)	(2.0)
N	1312	1106	109865	20965460
Variables Based on the 1940 Census				
Years of Education	11.7	11.6	10.1	9.0
	(2.6)	(2.7)	(3.4)	(3.5)
Age at Appointment	38.1	37.1	-	-
	(9.9)	(9.5)	-	-
N	2311	1242	138562	40803176

The table compares the predetermined characteristics of women postmasters appointed between 1921 and 1939 with the general female population. All samples are further restricted to be between ages 18-65. The outcome variables are years of education, age at appointment, age in 1920, whether one was White and native born (*100), urban and farm status in 1920 (*100), whether one was currently married in 1920 (*100), whether one/one's husband was gainfully employed in 1920 (*100), whether one/one's husband was self-employed in 1920 (*100), and whether one was a homeowner in 1920 (*100) and the number of children in the household in 1920 (conditional on head/spouse). The availability of variables varies by different samples and censuses. Postmaster data are weighted by inverse probability weights.

Table 2: Validity of RD - Predetermined Characteristics for Women Postmasters Appointed Just Before and After the 1933 Presidential Transition

	(1) Number of Obs	(2) RD Estimate	(3) Standard Errors
Variables from Sample of Women PM			
Republican Vote 1928 %	5728	1.930	(3.07)
Sales Loss PC 1929-1933	5728	-1.495	(16.03)
Father's OCCScore Rank	5728	0.012	(0.01)
Linked to 1940	5728	-0.026	(0.10)
Linked to 1920	5728	0.083	(0.07)
Variables from Sample of Linked Women PM (1940)			
Years of Education	2443	0.861	(0.71)
Age at Appointment	2443	-1.854	(2.37)
Variables from Sample of Linked Women PM (1920)			
White	1929	0.053	(0.06)
Native Born	1929	0.005	(0.05)
Urban	1929	0.026	(0.08)
Farm	1929	-0.182	(0.16)
Married	1929	-0.256	(0.13)
Employed	1929	0.090	(0.10)
Conditional on Household Head/Spouse			
Homeowner	1316	-0.020	(0.16)
# Children	1316	0.386	(0.45)

The table displays the RD estimates on pre-determined characteristics for women postmasters appointed between 1921 and 1939. The running variable is the distance between the initial appointment date and the presidential transition date (March 4, 1933). The outcome variables are county-level Republican vote share in 1928, county-level sales loss per capita between 1929 and 1933, father's OCCScore rank, the probability of the postmaster being linked to the 1940/1920 census, years of education, age at the appointment, whether one was White/native born/married/gainfully employed in 1920, farm and urban status in 1920, whether one was a homeowner in 1920 (conditional on head/spouse), and the number of children in the household in 1920 (conditional on head/spouse). Standard errors are clustered by the running variable (Lee and Card, 2008), and linked data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights (Bailey et al., 2020). The availability of variables varies by different samples and censuses. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table 3: RD Estimates by Gender - 1940 Outcomes of Postmasters Appointed Just Before and After the 1933 Presidential Transition

	(1) Postmaster Occ	(2) Employed	(3) Weeks Worked	(4) Hours Worked	(5) Self-Employed	(6) Family Worker
Panel A: RD Estimates on Women Postmasters						
Sharp RD	0.342***	0.239*	16.865***	11.111*	-0.035	-0.027
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(3.94)	(4.93)	(0.05)	(0.02)
Fuzzy RD		0.637***	43.945***	27.891**	-0.091	-0.050
		(0.19)	(9.44)	(9.14)	(0.13)	(0.05)
N Women	2443	2443	2443	2443	2443	2443
N Effective	818	836	1242	944	846	1300
Bandwidth	742.5	760.7	1172.9	872.7	779.3	1193.0
Panel B: RD Estimates on Male Postmasters						
Sharp RD	0.533***	-0.017	-1.032	1.618	-0.338***	-0.008
	(0.06)	(0.03)	(3.05)	(2.67)	(0.09)	(0.01)
Fuzzy RD		-0.070	-0.944	5.138	-0.660***	-0.016
		(0.07)	(5.38)	(7.24)	(0.17)	(0.02)
N Men	8085	8085	8085	8085	8085	8085
N Effective	2472	2577	1999	3310	2134	2933
Bandwidth	673.9	707.3	472.7	885.5	518.7	792.5
Panel C: Gender Differences in Sharp RD Estimates						
Sharp RD	0.19	-0.256**	-17.897**	-9.493	-0.302**	0.019
Difference	(0.12)	(0.11)	(4.98)	(5.61)	(0.11)	(0.02)
N Total	10528	10528	10528	10528	10528	10528

The table reports sharp and fuzzy RD estimates between postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition for women (Panel A) and men (Panel B). The gender differences in RD are reported in Panel C. The outcome variables are whether one reported postmaster being their occupation in 1940, whether they were employed in 1940, the number of weeks worked per year in 1939, the number of hours worked per week, whether the postmaster was a family worker in 1940, and whether the postmaster was self-employed in 1940. Control variables include age, age squared, whether one was native-born/married/migrated during the last five years, and farm/urban status. It additionally reports clustered standard errors by the running variable, the number of effective observations, and the optimal bandwidth. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table 4: Top 1940 Occupations for Women Postmasters Appointed Before the 1933 Presidential Transition

	(1) All Women	(2) Married Women	(3) Unmarried Women	(4) Rural Women	(5) Urban Women
Clerical Workers	11.8	9.1	13.5	11.4	14.3
(occ1950=390)	(32.3)	(28.9)	(34.2)	(31.8)	(35.3)
Managers, Officials, and Proprietors	9.2	10.4	8.5	9.5	7.2
(occ1950=290)	(28.9)	(30.6)	(27.9)	(29.4)	(26.0)
Bookkeepers	5.8	5.0	6.3	5.9	5.6
(occ1950=310)	(23.5)	(21.9)	(24.4)	(23.5)	(23.2)
Teachers	5.7	5.7	5.7	5.2	9.0
(occ1950=93)	(23.3)	(23.3)	(23.3)	(22.3)	(28.9)
Salesmen	4.5	4.1	4.6	4.1	6.6
(occ1950=490)	(20.6)	(20.0)	(21.1)	(19.9)	(25.0)
Officials, Public Admin	2.8	1.4	3.7	3.0	1.8
(occ1950=250)	(16.5)	(11.6)	(18.8)	(17.0)	(13.3)
Farmers (Owner)	2.5	0.6	3.7	2.5	2.8
(occ1950=100)	(15.6)	(7.8)	(18.8)	(15.5)	(16.7)
Stenographers	1.5	1.4	1.5	1.7	0.0
(occ1950=350)	(12.1)	(11.9)	(12.2)	(12.9)	(0.0)
Boarding House Keepers	1.4	0.6	1.8	1.0	3.4
(occ1950=752)	(11.6)	(8.0)	(13.3)	(10.2)	(18.3)
Telephone Operators	1.3	1.9	1.0	1.5	0.0
(occ1950=370)	(11.4)	(13.7)	(9.7)	(12.2)	(0.0)
Insurance Agents	1.3	1.0	1.4	1.5	0.0
(occ1950=450)	(11.2)	(10.0)	(12.0)	(12.1)	(0.0)
N	444	175	269	387	57

The table summarizes the top 1940 occupations for women postmasters appointed before the 1933 presidential transition, conditional on those who reported a valid occupation other than the postmaster. Columns show the share of women engaged in a specific occupation in the respective sample. The occupational code for the variable occ1950 is shown for each occupation. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights (Bailey et al., 2020).

Table 5: DID Estimates on Employment Between Women Postmasters and Women Neighbors

	Outcome: Employed					
Bandwidth	*1400*	*1600*	*1800*	*2000*	*2200*	*2400*
Panel A: Women PM Appointed Before the 1933 Transition v.s. Neighbors						
$PM_i \times Post_t$	-0.054	-0.059	-0.106	-0.102	-0.090	-0.067
	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)
PM_i	0.149**	0.157**	0.189***	0.192***	0.190***	0.171***
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
$Post_t$	0.022	0.031	0.052	0.062	0.060	0.046
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
N	851	945	1072	1228	1296	1380
Neighborhood FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Education FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Panel B: Women PM Appointed After the 1933 Transition v.s. Neighbors						
$PM_i \times Post_t$	0.584***	0.572***	0.562***	0.556***	0.550***	0.552***
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
PM_i	0.024	0.032	0.021	0.029	0.031	0.033
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
$Post_t$	0.053*	0.052*	0.057**	0.057**	0.064**	0.069***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
N	2212	2328	2394	2477	2531	2635
Neighborhood FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Education FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

The table reports DID estimates on the employment outcome between women who had been postmasters and their women neighbors (who had never been postmasters). The pre-period is 1920 and the post-period is 1940. Neighborhood and Education fixed effects are included. Panel A shows the results for women postmasters appointed before the 1933 presidential transitions, and Panel B shows the results for women postmasters appointed after the 1933 presidential transitions. Different columns indicate different samples of women postmasters who were appointed within 1400/1600/1800/2000/2200/2400 days of the 1933 presidential transition. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table 6: RD Estimates on Additional Occupational Outcomes for Women

	(1) Full-Time Occupation	(2) Skilled Occupation	(3) Part-Time Occupation
Sharp RD	0.277**	0.217*	-0.023
	(0.09)	(0.10)	(0.02)
N	2443	2443	2443
	(4) Indicator for 1940 Wages > 0	(5) Wages in 1940	(6) ln Wages in 1940
Sharp RD	0.320***	753.032***	0.277
	(0.09)	(175.87)	(0.22)
N	2443	2280	1620

The table reports sharp RD estimates comparing women postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition. Outcomes include indicators for working in a full-time occupation ($\geq$40 weeks/year and $\geq$35 hours/week), a skilled occupation (OCC1950 codes 0–690, excluding farmers), a part-time occupation (positive weeks$\leq$25/year and positive hours$\leq$20/week). Additional outcomes include an indicator for earning positive wages in 1940, total wages in 1940 (including zeros), and the natural logarithm of wages in 1940 (excluding zeros). Control variables include age, age squared, whether one was native-born, married, or migrated during the last five years, and farm/urban status. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted using inverse probability weights. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Table 7: RD Estimates by Heterogeneous Factors for Women

	(1) Postmaster Occ	(2) Employed	(3) Weeks Worked	(4) Hours Worked	(5) Self-Employed	(6) Family Worker
Panel A: Women from High Socioeconomic Backgrounds						
Sharp RD	0.213	0.501**	28.224**	21.318**	0.087*	-0.084
	(0.23)	(0.19)	(9.30)	(8.13)	(0.04)	(0.05)
N	951	951	951	951	951	951
Panel B: Women from Low Socioeconomic Backgrounds						
Sharp RD	0.408**	0.217	14.785	10.438	-0.118	0.019
	(0.14)	(0.15)	(7.67)	(9.24)	(0.08)	(0.01)
N	1386	1386	1386	1386	1386	1386
Panel C: States w. Legislation against Married Women Working						
Sharp RD	0.432***	0.318**	18.797***	12.672*	-0.001	-0.027
	(0.10)	(0.12)	(4.83)	(6.12)	(0.03)	(0.02)
N	1633	1633	1633	1633	1633	1633
Panel D: States w/o Legislation against Married Women Working						
Sharp RD	0.341*	0.030	9.914	4.786	-0.141	-0.013
	(0.14)	(0.17)	(8.52)	(10.29)	(0.11)	(0.05)
N	810	810	810	810	810	810
Panel E: Counties w. Above Median Retail Sales Loss Per Capita						
Sharp RD	0.398***	0.406**	22.638***	14.679*	0.069*	-0.048
	(0.10)	(0.13)	(5.63)	(7.12)	(0.03)	(0.04)
N	1469	1469	1469	1469	1469	1469
Panel F: Counties w. Below Median Retail Sales Loss Per Capita						
Sharp RD	0.337	-0.253	-2.807	-0.204	-0.369*	0.005
	(0.21)	(0.19)	(8.84)	(11.28)	(0.18)	(0.01)
N	974	974	974	974	974	974

The table reports RD Results between women postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition by heterogeneous factors. Panels A and B compare women from high/low socioeconomic background. Panels C and D compare women from states with/without state-level discrimination against married women. Panels E and F compare women living in areas with above/below median level of the severity of the Great Depression (measured by retail sales loss per capita between 1929 and 1933). The outcome variables are whether one reported postmaster being their occupation in 1940, whether they were employed in 1940, the number of weeks worked per year in 1939, the number of hours worked per week, whether the postmaster was self-employed in 1940, and whether the postmaster was a family worker in 1940. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

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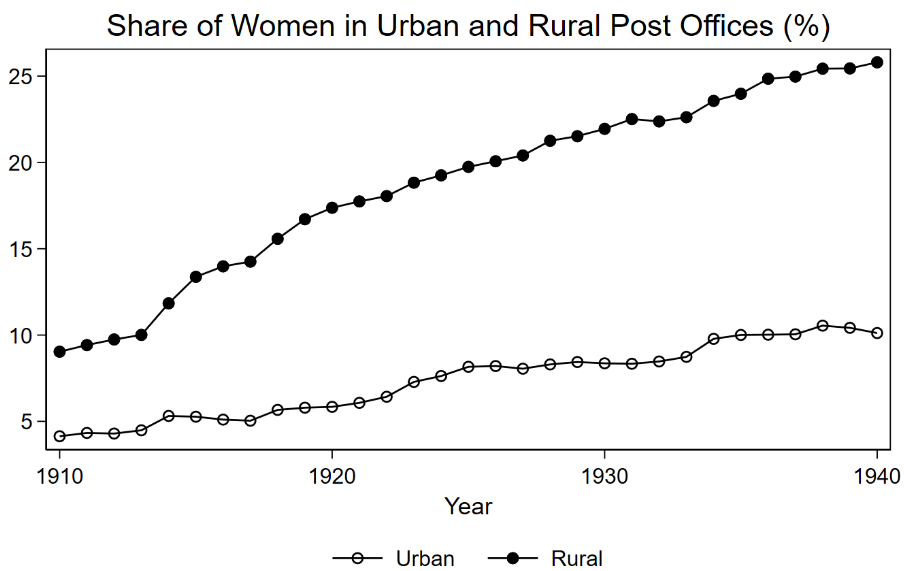
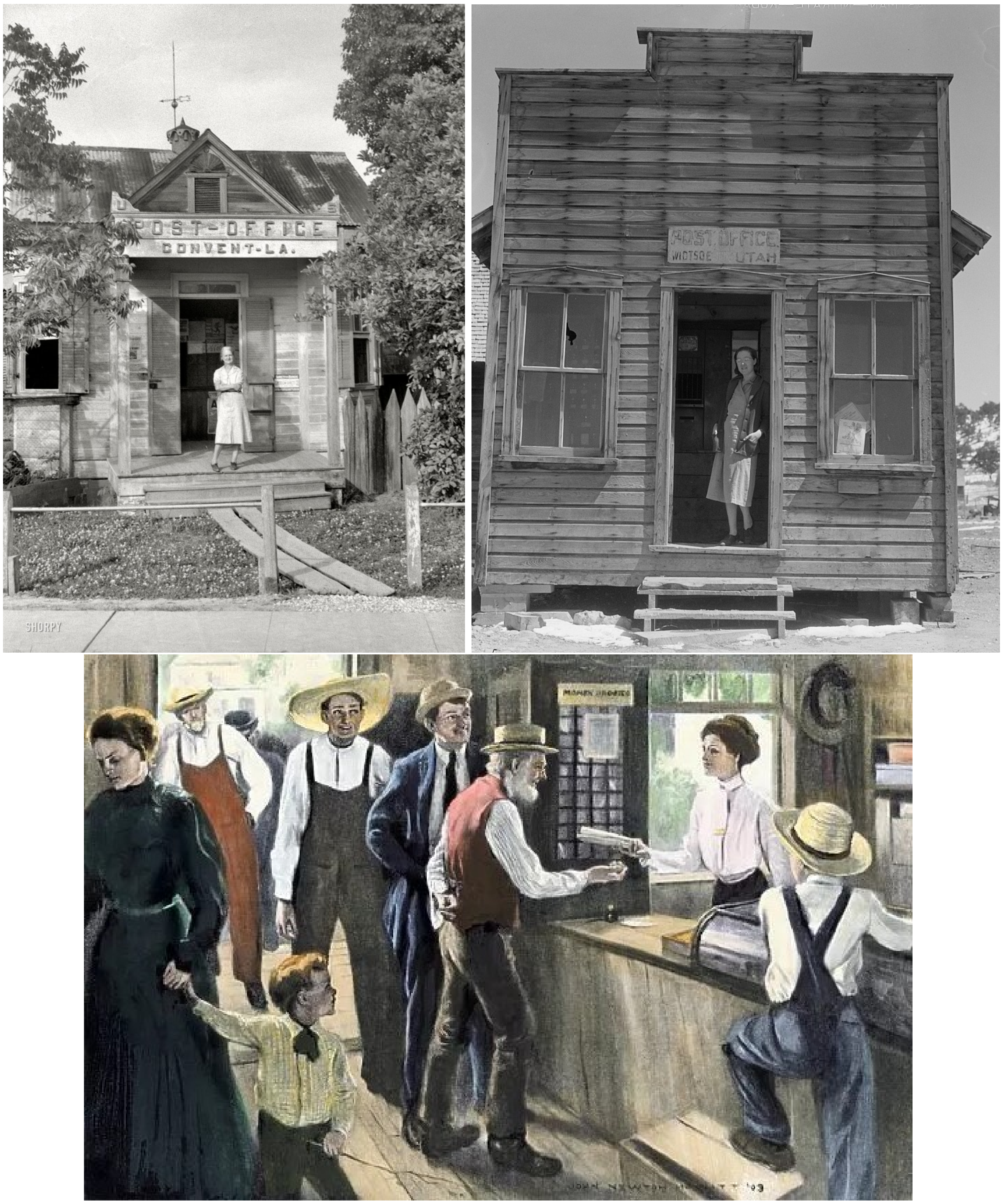
12 Appendix: Additional Figures, Tables and Analyses

Figure A1: Share of Postmasters Who Were Women in Urban and Rural Post Offices



The figure shows the share of women postmasters in urban and rural post offices between 1910 and 1940. Urban post offices were defined as Class 1 and Class 2 post offices, and rural post offices were defined as Class 3 post offices (based on the definition in the Postal Guide). The shares are calculated based on the dataset "Record of Appointment of Postmasters, 1832-1971".

Figure A2: Work Arrangements of Women Postmasters



Top left: Photo of a woman postmaster in Covent, Louisiana, taken by John Vachon for the Farm Security Administration. Top right: Photo of a woman postmaster in a Utah post office published by the National Postal Museum. Bottom: the reproduction of a 1905 illustration, "Meeting the new postmistress, early 1900s" (original source unknown).

Figure A3: Number of Postmasters Removed during the Late-Nineteenth Century

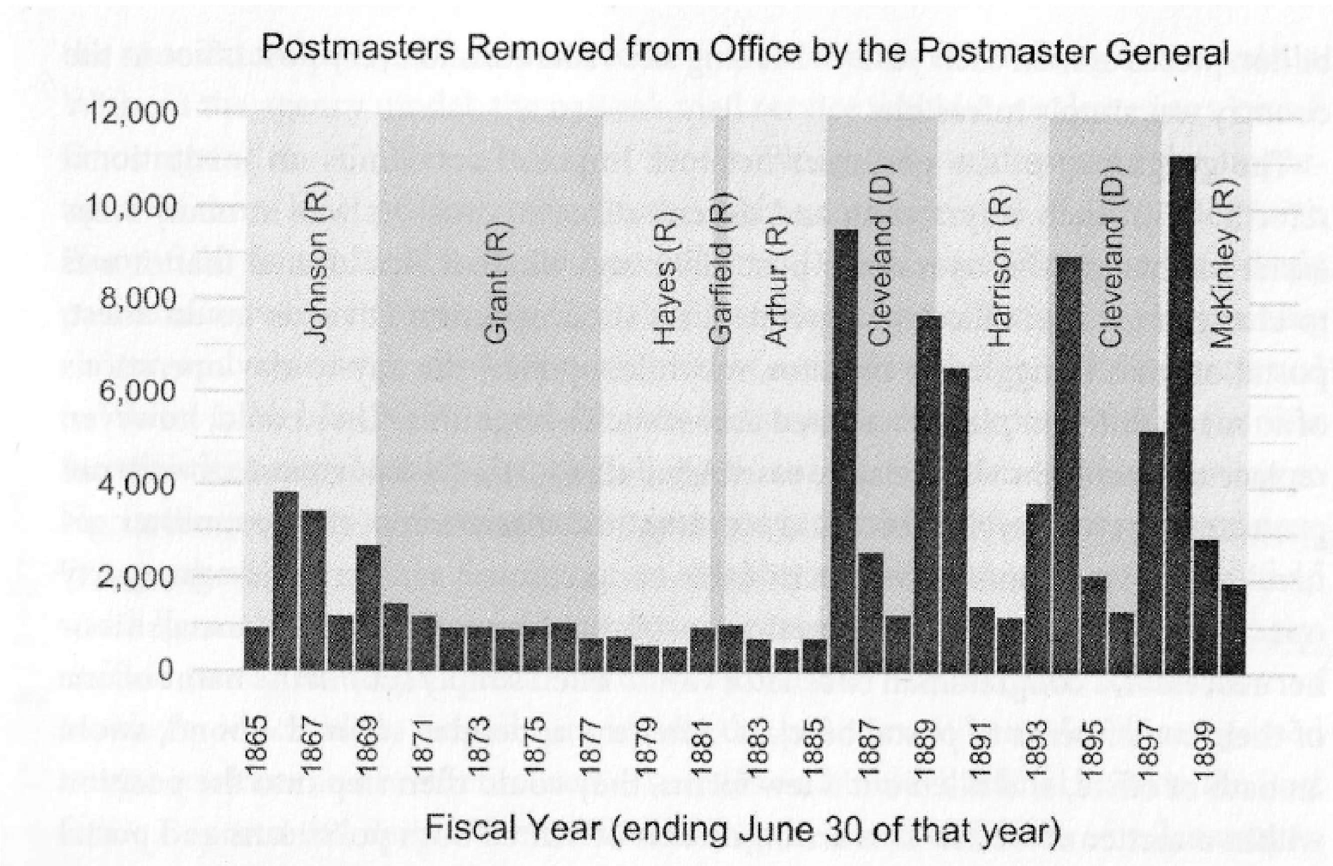
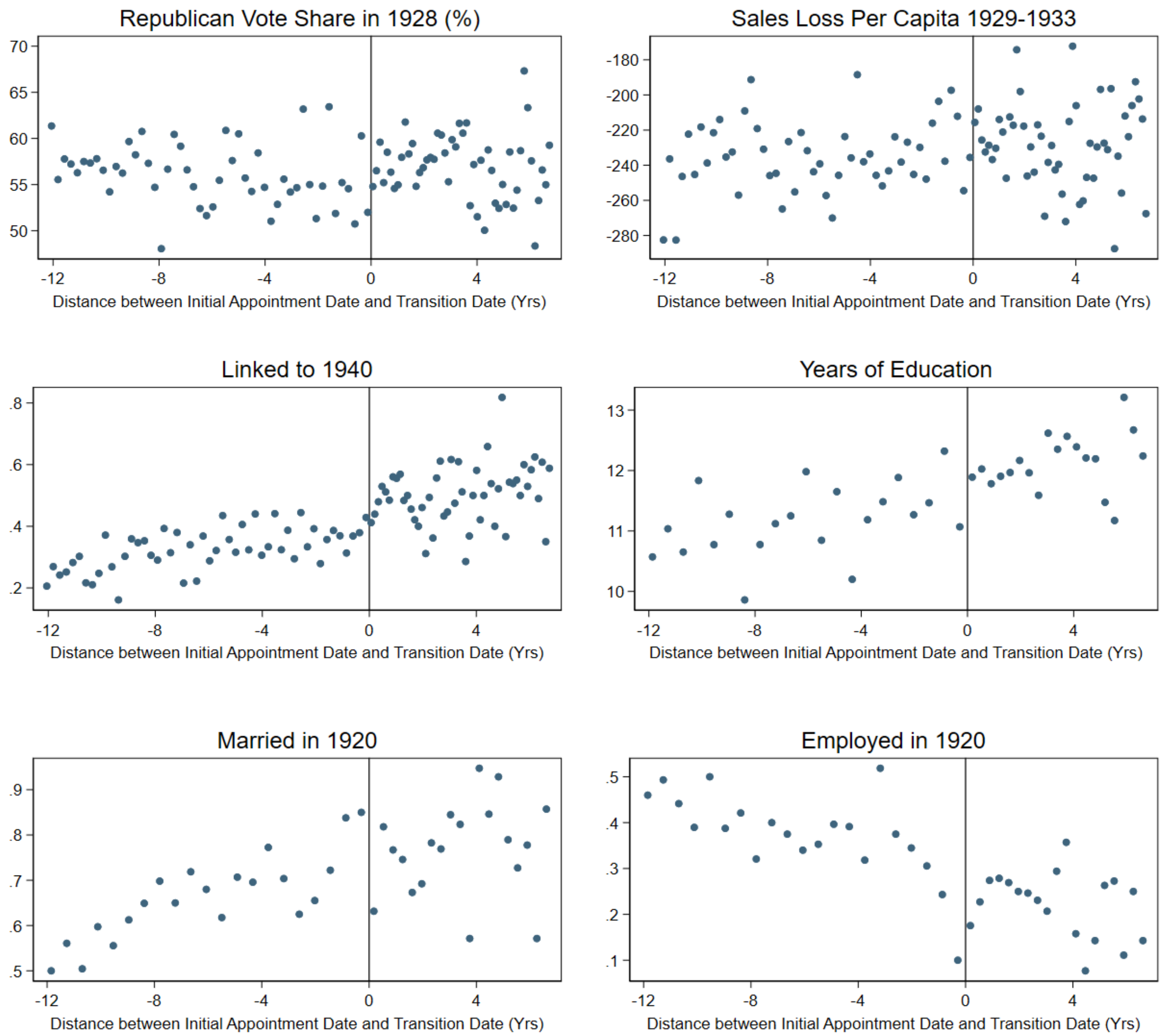


Figure 5.10 The Spoils System

This chart displays the number of postmasters who were removed from office over the preceding fiscal year (July 1 to June 30) between 1865 and 1900. These numbers were transcribed from the Annual Reports of the Postmaster General, 1865–1900.

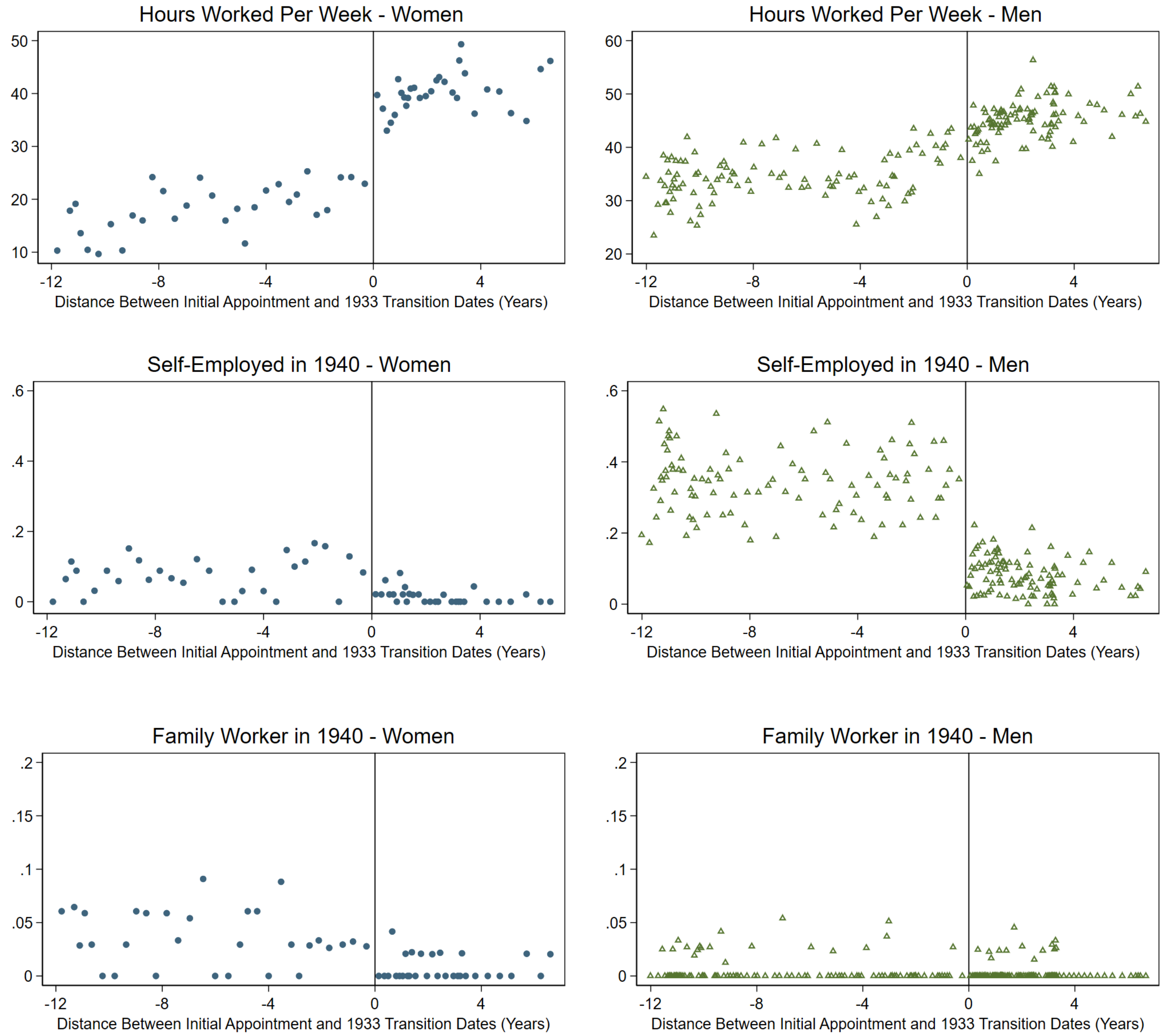
The figure shows the number of postmasters removed in each fiscal year during the late-nineteenth Century United States (Blevins, 2021).

Figure A4: Validity of RD – Pre-Determined Characteristics for Women Postmasters Appointed Just Before and Just After the 1933 Presidential Transition



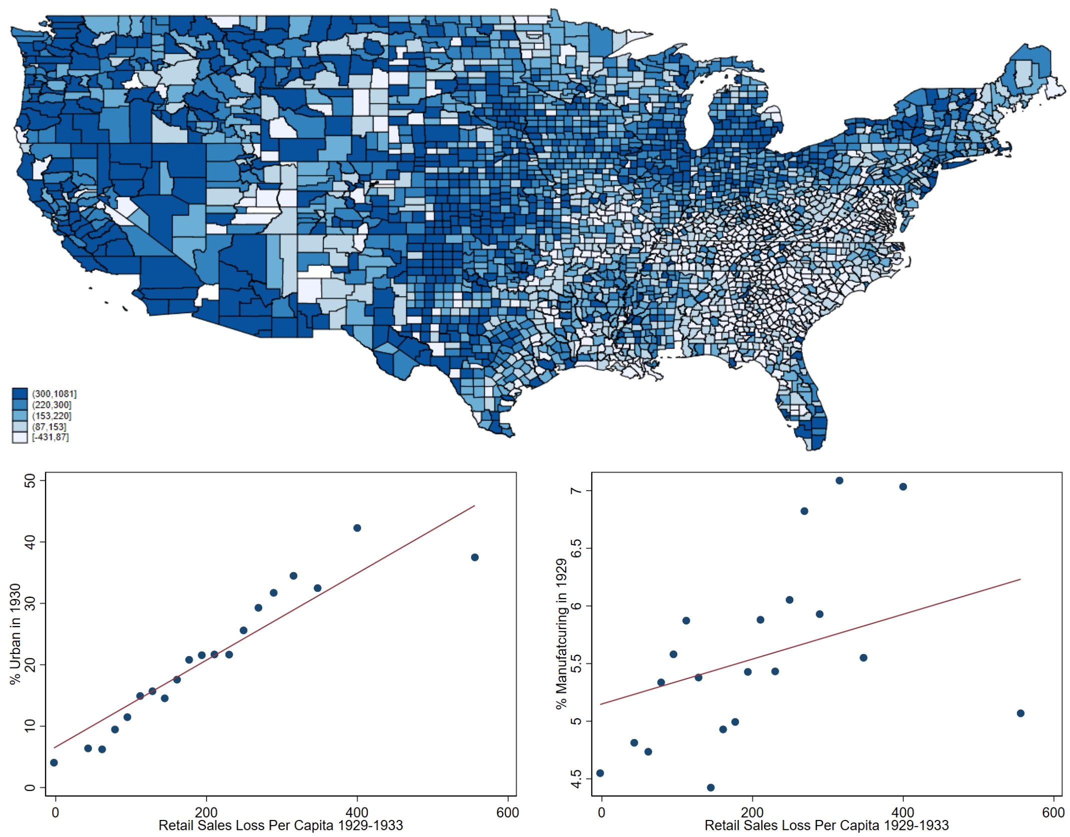
The figures plot pre-determined characteristics for women postmasters. The running variable is the standardized distance between the initial appointment and the 1933 presidential transition dates. The outcome variables are county-level Republican vote share in 1928, county-level sales loss per capita between 1929 and 1933, whether the postmaster is linked to the 1940 census, the postmaster's years of education, and whether the postmaster was married/gainfully employed in 1920. The first three variables are from the full sample of women postmasters, and the last three variables are from the linked sample of women postmasters. Data are plotted in quantile-spaced bins, and each bin contains roughly 40 observations. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. The availability of variables varies by different samples and censuses (see more details in Table 2).

Figure A5: Additional RD Results on 1940 Outcomes Between Postmasters Appointed Just Before and Just After the 1933 Presidential Transition - By Gender



The figure shows RD Results between postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition for women (left column) and men (right column). The outcome variables are the number of hours worked per week, whether the postmaster was self-employed in 1940, and whether the postmaster was a family worker in 1940. The sample is linked data between postmaster appointments and the 1940 complete-count census. The running variable is the standardized distance between the initial appointment and the 1933 presidential transition dates. Data are plotted in quantile-spaced bins, and each bin contains roughly 40 observations. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights.

Figure A6: Severity of the Great Depression - Measured by Retail Sales Loss Per Capita between 1929 and 1933



The figure at the top shows variations in county-level retail sales loss per capita between 1929 and 1933. The median is $185 (in 1967 $). The two figures at the bottom show the correlation between (1) % urban population and retail sales loss per capita and (2) % manufacturing population and retail sales loss per capita.

Table A1: RD Estimates for Women and Men - Mechanical and Substitution Effects

	(1) Employed	(2) Weeks Worked	(3) Hours Worked
Panel A: RD Estimates for Women			
RD - Mechanical	0.342***	19.304***	11.924*
	(0.10)	(4.18)	(5.57)
RD - Substitution	0.225*	13.160**	9.734
	(0.10)	(4.55)	(5.25)
N	2443	2443	2443
Panel B: RD Estimates for Men			
RD - Mechanical	0.533***	26.652***	23.875***
	(0.06)	(2.24)	(3.43)
RD - Substitution	0.123*	5.910	6.307
	(0.05)	(3.40)	(3.64)
N	8085	8085	8085

The RD mechanical effect is estimated by setting all outcomes to zero if the individual did not report postmaster as their occupation in 1940. The RD substitution effect is estimated by setting all outcomes to zero if the individual did not report the postmaster occupation or another white-collar occupation in 1940. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table A2: Top 1940 Occupations for Male Postmasters Appointed Before the 1933 Presidential Transition

	(1) All Men	(2) Married Men	(3) Unmarried Men	(4) Rural Men	(5) Urban Men
Managers, Officials, Proprietors	23.3	25.0	12.3	23.1	23.6
(occ1950=290)	(42.3)	(43.3)	(32.9)	(42.2)	(42.5)
Farmers (Owner)	11.4	11.9	8.0	14.9	2.5
(occ1950=100)	(31.7)	(32.4)	(27.1)	(35.6)	(15.7)
Clerical Workers	5.8	5.5	7.4	5.4	6.9
(occ1950=390)	(23.4)	(22.9)	(26.2)	(22.5)	(25.3)
Salesmen	4.7	4.4	6.4	4.3	5.7
(occ1950=490)	(21.1)	(20.5)	(24.4)	(20.2)	(23.1)
Insurance Agents	4.1	4.4	2.0	3.4	5.7
(occ1950=450)	(19.8)	(20.5)	(14.1)	(18.2)	(23.3)
Officials, Public Admin	3.9	3.9	4.0	3.4	5.1
(occ1950=250)	(19.3)	(19.3)	(19.5)	(18.1)	(22.0)
Laborers	3.6	2.7	9.2	3.6	3.5
(occ1950=970)	(18.5)	(16.1)	(28.9)	(18.6)	(18.4)
Bookkeepers	2.7	2.9	1.7	2.3	3.9
(occ1950=310)	(16.3)	(16.8)	(13.1)	(14.9)	(19.3)
Operatives	2.3	2.1	3.9	2.3	2.3
(occ1950=690)	(15.1)	(14.3)	(19.3)	(15.1)	(15.0)
Lawyers	1.6	1.5	2.5	1.5	2.0
(occ1950=55)	(12.7)	(12.2)	(15.5)	(12.1)	(14.1)
Real Estate Agents	1.6	1.7	1.2	1.4	2.3
(occ1950=470)	(12.7)	(13.0)	(11.0)	(11.6)	(15.1)
N	3149	2721	428	2285	864

The table summarizes the top 1940 occupations for male postmasters appointed before the 1933 presidential transition, conditional on those who reported a valid occupation other than the postmaster. Columns show the share of men engaged in a specific occupation in the respective sample. The occupational code for the variable occ1950 is shown for each occupation. Data are weighted by inverse probability weights.

Table A3: Robustness Checks on RD Estimates (Women Only) - 1940 Outcomes of Postmasters Appointed Just Before and After the 1933 Presidential Transition

	(1) Postmaster Occ	(2) Employed	(3) Weeks Worked	(4) Hours Worked	(5) Self-Employed	(6) Family Worker
A. Bias-Corrected Estimates						
RD Estimate	0.312**	0.225*	17.142***	10.690*	-0.032	-0.031
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(3.94)	(4.93)	(0.05)	(0.02)
B. Epanechnikov Kernel Density						
RD Estimate	0.409***	0.231*	16.272***	10.978*	-0.041	-0.030
	(0.08)	(0.10)	(4.14)	(4.86)	(0.05)	(0.02)
C. Bandwidth = 1000 Days						
RD Estimate	0.404***	0.249**	16.090***	11.298*	-0.022	-0.021
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(4.32)	(4.64)	(0.05)	(0.02)
D. County-level Controls						
RD Estimate	0.326**	0.244*	16.706***	11.099*	-0.033	-0.025
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(4.03)	(4.95)	(0.05)	(0.02)
E. Age Group Fixed Effects						
RD Estimate	0.329**	0.240*	16.679***	11.052*	-0.040	-0.025
	(0.10)	(0.11)	(4.19)	(4.90)	(0.05)	(0.02)
F. Placebo Test						
RD Estimate	-0.113	-0.003	2.034	1.175	0.081	-0.035
	(0.11)	(0.15)	(7.60)	(6.94)	(0.07)	(0.04)
N	2443	2443	2443	2443	2443	2443
G. Donut RD dropping obs appointed after the 1932 election						
RD Estimate	0.514***	0.207*	14.743**	11.065*	-0.188	-0.036
	(0.15)	(0.10)	(4.99)	(5.38)	(0.10)	(0.04)
N	2371	2371	2371	2371	2371	2371

The table reports robustness checks on RD estimates from Table 3. Panel A to Panel G report RD results with (A) bias-corrected RD estimates; (B) an Epanechnikov kernel density function; (C) bandwidth = 1000 days; (D) county-level control variables; (E) age group fixed effects; (F) a placebo test where the placebo presidential transition date is March 4th, 1926; (G) a donut RD design where observations within the distance between the election date in 1932 and the transition date in 1933 are dropped. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table A4: DID Estimates on Employment Between Women Postmasters and Their 1920 Women Neighbors: Robustness to Control Group Choice

	Outcome: Employed					
Bandwidth	*1400*	*1600*	*1800*	*2000*	*2200*	*2400*
Panel A: Women PM Appointed Before the 1933 Transition v.s. Women Neighbors (±5 Microfilm Pages)						
$PM_i \times Post_t$	-0.044	-0.044	-0.086	-0.074	-0.063	-0.045
	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)
N Total	5970	6695	7687	8731	9267	10073
Neighborhood FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Education FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Panel B: Women PM Appointed Before the 1933 Transition v.s. Women Neighbors in the Same County						
$PM_i \times Post_t$	0.038	0.022	-0.006	0.033	0.043	0.055
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)
N Total	587615	611759	674916	836824	876366	908945
County FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Education FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Panel C: Women PM Appointed Before the 1933 Transition v.s. Women Neighbors in the Same County (Skilled Occ Only)						
$PM_i \times Post_t$	0.052	0.075	0.075	0.084	0.105	0.122
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)
N Total	11252	11390	13750	14848	15687	15695
County FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Education FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

The table reports DID estimates on the employment outcome between women postmasters appointed before the 1933 presidential transition and their women neighbors. Different columns indicate different samples of women postmasters who were appointed within 1400/1600/1800/2000/2200/2400 days of the 1933 transition, along with their matched neighbors. Panels A, B and C vary the definition of neighbors: (A) women recorded within a five-page range of the postmaster in the 1920 complete-count census; (B) women residing in the same county as the postmaster; and (C) women residing in the same county as the postmaster and employed in skilled occupations. All specifications include neighborhood (or county) and education fixed effects and apply inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

Table A5: Comparison of Job Characteristics in 1940

	(1) Other Occ	(2) Postmaster
Mean(Weeks Worked)	44.4	44.1
	(15.0)	(17.6)
Median(Weeks Worked)	52.0	52.0
	(15.0)	(17.6)
Mean(Hours Worked)	38.9	39.9
	(21.9)	(21.6)
Median(Hours Worked)	45.0	48.0
	(21.9)	(21.6)
N	444	1441
Mean(Wages)	962.4	1515.8
	(768.2)	(798.0)
Median(Wages)	900.0	1600.0
	(768.4)	(797.9)
N	425	1386

The table compares characteristics of jobs held in 1940 by women who could not be reappointed as postmasters ("Other Occ") and women who could continue as postmasters ("Postmaster"). Reported statistics include the mean and median weeks worked per year, hours worked per week, and annual wages in 1940 dollars. Sample sizes differ slightly for wage outcomes due to missing values.

Table A6: RD Estimates For Women By Years of Education

	(1) Postmaster Occ	(2) Employed	(3) Weeks Worked	(4) Hours Worked	(5) Self-Employed	(6) Family Worker
Panel A: Years of Education ≥ 12						
RD Estimate	0.336*	0.425**	24.511***	18.544***	-0.021	-0.047
	(0.15)	(0.14)	(5.17)	(5.56)	(0.06)	(0.03)
N	1586	1586	1586	1586	1586	1586
Panel B: Years of Education < 12						
RD Estimate	0.201	-0.010	1.276	-5.921	-0.062	0.017
	(0.17)	(0.15)	(8.97)	(10.59)	(0.08)	(0.01)
N	857	857	857	857	857	857

The table reports RD estimates between women postmasters appointed just before and after the 1933 presidential transition by years of education. The outcome variables are whether one reported postmaster being their occupation in 1940, whether they were employed in 1940, the number of weeks worked per year in 1939, the number of hours worked per week, whether the postmaster was self-employed in 1940, and whether the postmaster was a family worker in 1940. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$

12.1 Sample of Postmasters and Post Offices in the Analysis

Post offices were classified into Classes 1 through 4 based on revenue and postmaster salaries. Class 1 post offices, typically located in metropolitan areas, were the largest and handled the highest volume of mail and parcels. Class 4 post offices, in contrast, were the smallest, serving local towns of only a few hundred residents. Correspondingly, postmaster salaries varied with class: in the early 20th century, Class 1 postmasters earned between \$5,000 and \$10,000 per year, while over 70 percent of Class 4 postmasters received less than \$100 annually (Hoogenboom, 1959). Classifications were revised every two years to reflect changes in mail volume and revenue, although most adjustments were small.

The analysis focuses on full-time postmasters who were presidential appointees, namely those serving in Classes 1, 2, and 3. Class 4 postmasters are excluded because these positions were removed from presidential appointment between 1909 and 1913, when Presidents Theodore Roosevelt and William Howard Taft transferred them to the merit-based civil service system. Moreover, compensation at the Class 4 level was extremely low, and the position was unlikely to constitute full-time employment.

To document post office classifications and compensation, I digitize one volume of the Postal Guide, an official government document that reports the classification of each post office and the corresponding compensation for its postmaster (United States Government Printing Office, 1939). A sample image of the 1939 Postal Guide is available in Figure A7. Among women postmasters examined in the paper, the vast majority (82%) held Class 3 positions, with only 3% serving as Class 1 postmasters. The median salary for these women postmasters were \$1,600.

Figure A7: Sample Image of US Official Postal Guide, 1939

Classified List of Post Offices, With Salaries 877

CONNECTICUT—Continued

Office	Class	Salary
Glastonbury GV	2	$2,700
Glenville	3	2,000
Granby	3	1,600
Greens Farms	2	2,400
Greenwich G F	1	5,000
Guilford F	2	2,400
Haddam	3	1,600
Hartford G F	1	7,000
Hazardville	3	1,700
Higganum	3	1,800
Ivoryton	2	2,500
Jewett City F	2	2,500
Kensington V	2	2,500
Kent	3	2,300
Killingly	3	1,500
Lakeville	2	2,500
Litchfield	2	2,700
Madison	2	2,500
Manchester G F	1	3,500
Mansfield Depot	3	1,400
Meriden G F	1	3,900
Middlebury	3	1,900
Middlefield	3	2,300
Middletown G F	1	3,700
Milford G F	1	3,300
Milldale	3	2,200
Montville	3	2,100
Moodus	3	2,300
Moosup	3	2,200
Mystic G F	2	2,700
Naugatuck G F	1	3,500
New Britain G F	1	4,200
New Canaan F	1	3,200
New Hartford	3	2,000
New Haven G F	1	7,000
Newington	3	2,200
New London G F	1	3,800
New Milford G F	2	2,900
New Preston	3	1,700
Newtown	3	2,300
Niantic	2	2,400
Noank	3	1,600
Norfolk	2	2,400
Noroton	3	2,200
Noroton Heights	3	2,200
North Grosvenor Dale	3	1,900
North Haven	3	2,100
North Stonington	3	1,200
Norwalk G F	1	3,600
Norwich G F	1	3,700

CONNECTICUT—Continued

Office	Class	Salary
South Norwalk G F	1	$3,800
Southport	2	2,500
South Willington	3	1,700
Springdale F	2	2,500
Stafford Springs F	2	2,500
Stamford G F	1	4,500
Stepney Depot	3	1,800
Sterling	3	1,600
Stonington F	2	2,500
Stony Creek	3	1,600
Suffield V	3	2,200
Taftville	3	2,100
Terryville	2	2,500
Thomaston G F	2	2,700
Thompson	3	1,500
Thompsonville G F	2	2,900
Torrington G F	1	3,600
Uncasville	3	1,900
Unionville V	2	2,500
Versailles	3	1,600
Voluntown	3	1,300
Wallingford G F	1	3,500
Warehouse Point	3	1,700
Washington	3	2,100
Washington Depot	3	2,100
Waterbury G F	1	4,500
Waterford	3	2,000
Watertown F	2	2,700
Wauregan	3	1,300
Westbrook	3	2,300
West Cheshire	3	2,100
West Cornwall	3	1,500
Westport G F	1	3,400
West Willington	3	1,400
Willimantic G F	1	3,300
Wilton	3	2,300
Windsor F	2	2,700
Windsor Locks F	2	2,400
Winsted G F	1	3,200
Woodbury	3	2,100
Woodmont	3	1,900
Yalesville	3	1,400
Yantic	3	1,500

DELAWARE

Office	Class	Salary
Bellevue	3	1,100
Bridgeville	3	2,300
Camden	3	1,600
Cheswold	3	1,200
Claymont V	2	2,400

DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

Office	Class	Salary
Washington G F	1	$10,000

FLORIDA

Office	Class	Salary
Alachua	3	1,900
Altamonte Springs	3	1,200
Altha	3	1,400
Apalachicola G F	2	2,400
Apopka	2	2,400
Arcadia G F	2	2,600
Archer	3	1,400
Atlantic Beach	3	1,800
Auburndale	2	2,400
Avon Park	2	2,500
Babson Park	3	1,700
Bagdad	3	1,200
Baker	3	1,300
Bartow G F	2	2,800
Bay Harbor	3	1,700
Bay Pines	3	1,800
Belleair	3	1,100
Belle Glade	3	2,300
Blountstown	3	2,100
Bocagrande	3	1,900
Boca Raton	3	1,900
Bonifay V	3	2,200
Bowling Green	3	1,600
Boynton	3	1,900
Bradenton G F	1	3,300
Branford	3	1,600
Brewster	3	1,400
Bronson	3	1,100
Brooksville F	2	2,400
Bunnell	3	1,900
Bushnell	3	1,900
Callahan	3	1,500
Canal Point	3	1,700
Carrabelle	3	1,600
Cedar Keys	3	1,400
Center Hill	3	1,500
Century	3	1,700
Chattahoochee	3	2,300
Chiefland	3	1,400
Chipley V	2	2,400
Citra	3	1,100
Clearwater G F	1	3,400
Clermont	2	2,400
Clewiston	2	2,400
Cocoa	2	2,600
Coronado Beach	3	1,400
Cottondale	3	1,500

The figure shows the postmaster salary and level of classification for post offices in Connecticut, Delaware, District of Columbia, and Florida in 1939 (United States Government Printing Office, 1939). For example, the Clermont post office in Florida was a Class 2 post office, which suggested that it was one of the larger post offices in urban areas. The postmaster's salary was $2,400.

12.2 Eligibility of Postmaster Candidates and Civil Service Exams

The Civil Service Commission established several minimum requirements for postmaster candidates. For example, the candidate must be a US citizen, and a naturalized citizen is acceptable. Male candidates must be 21 years old and above, and female candidates must be 18 and above. The candidate must also reside in the delivery area of the post office he or she would be in charge of (United States Civil Service Commission, 1916).

Meeting the minimum requirement only made the candidate eligible for the civil service exam, while only the top candidates from the exam would be considered for the position. Candidates for postmasters were tested on a few subjects. The most important subject was arithmetic which includes addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division. For example, one exam question asked the candidates to make an itemized list of transacted money orders over the past month, as well as to balance and close the statement based on fees charged in each money order. Arithmetic skills were necessary because postmasters must keep track of sales and receipts to report post office revenue correctly. Additional subjects included penmanship and letter writing which would help communication between post offices, efficient mail delivery, and many other post office businesses (United States Civil Service Commission, 1916).

Postmasters in larger post offices were subject to even higher standards. Specifically, postmasters in charge of Class 3 post offices and above must demonstrate “business training, experience, and fitness” and “the ability in meeting and dealing satisfactorily with the public” (United States Civil Service Commission, 1922). The demonstration often included a personal history of past business managing experience that needed to be verified by the civil service commission. The highest paying post offices specifically required more than 5 to 7 years of experience in similar types of employment (United States Civil Service Commission, 1922). Figure A8 shows the requirement for postmasters in charge of Class 3 post offices and an example question that asks the candidates to calculate the fees associated with money orders received in a post office.

Figure A8: Civil Service Exams Requirements for Postmasters

Subjects.	Weights.
1. Accounts and arithmetic (this test includes a simple statement of a postmaster's monthly money-order account in a prepared form, furnished the candidate in the examination, and a few problems comprising addition, subtraction, multiplication, division, percentage, and their business applications)........	3
2. Penmanship (a test of ability to write legibly, rated on the specimen shown in the subject of letter writing)........	1
3. Letter writing (this subject is intended to test the candidate's ability to express himself intelligently in a business letter on a practical subject)........	1
4. Business training, experience and fitness (under this subject, full and careful consideration is given to the candidate's business training and experience. The rating is based upon the candidate's sworn statements of his personal history, as verified after inquiry by the commission. It must be clearly shown that the candidate has demonstrated ability in meeting and dealing satisfactorily with the public)........	5
Total........	10

2. The money-order transactions at Avon, Mass., post office for the month of May, 1914, were as follows:

Money-order fund on hand May 1, $18. May 1, transferred from postal account to money-order account, $27. May 2, paid money order, $39.06. May 3, issued money order for $49.50. May 5, issued money order, $80.91. May 6, paid money order, $7.29. May 7, issued money order, $18.27. May 8, paid money order, $27.81. May 9, issued money order, $63. May 10, paid money order, $19.80. May 12, paid money order, 81 cents. May 13, issued money order, $4.77. May 14, paid money order, $9.27. May 15, issued money order, $29.07. May 16, paid money order, $9.72. May 17, issued money order, $9.72. May 19, issued money order, $57.24. May 20, paid money order, 99 cents. May 21, issued money order, 72 cents. May 22, paid money order, $45. May 23, issued money order, $36 May 24, paid money order, $2.97. May 26, paid money order, $7.29. May 27, issued money order, $72. May 28, paid money order, $9.72. May 29, issued money order, $4.59. May 30, postmaster deposited in the United States depository to the credit of the Post Office Department $90, and received a certificate of deposit. May 31, issued money order, $46.89. May 31, postmaster credited himself for errors as per auditor's circular, $1.62.

Make an itemized statement of the postmaster's money-order account in the form provided, and balance and close the statement.

Schedule of fees over and above the amount of the order which the postmaster must collect from the public for the Government on issue of money orders.

For orders from $0.01 to $2.50........	3 cents.	For orders from $30.01 to $40.00........	15 cents.
For orders from $2.51 to $5.00........	5 cents.	For orders from $40.01 to $50.00........	18 cents.
For orders from $5.01 to $10.00........	8 cents.	For orders from $50.01 to $60.00........	20 cents.
For orders from $10.01 to $20.00........	10 cents.	For orders from $60.01 to $75.00........	25 cents.
For orders from $20.01 to $30.00........	12 cents.	For orders from $75.01 to $100.00........	30 cents.

The figure shows the requirement for postmasters in charge of Class 3 post offices and an example question that asks the candidates to calculate the fees associated with money orders received in a specific post office (United States Civil Service Commission, 1916).

12.3 Linking Rates by Matching Criteria and Demographic Subgroups

Here, I provide additional details on the census linking procedure, including linking rates under alternative matching criteria and linking rates by demographic subgroups.

First, I calculate the share of postmasters who have at least 1 match and the share of postmasters who have a unique match in the census. As shown in Columns 1 and 2 in Table A7, between 48.1% and 84.6% of postmasters had at least one potential match in the census. However, imposing the requirement of a unique, non-duplicated match reduces the linking rate substantially, to between 16.3% and 39.0%. This decline likely reflects the prevalence of common names, for which identifying a unique individual in the census is difficult (e.g., "John Smith"). To address this issue, I apply inverse probability weights following Bailey et al., 2020, which reweigh the observations to balance the observed characteristics (such as the frequency of the name) of the linked sample with those of the full population of postmasters.

Table A7 further shows that incorporating county information in the census linking process is critical since it increases the probability of identifying a unique match, yielding linking rates of 39.1–46.8% for women, compared with only 17.8-24.9% when linking relies on state information alone. A similar pattern holds for men: including county raises the unique linking rate to 32.6-37.1%, relative to 15.9–21.3% under state-only matching.

Linking rates are also higher under fuzzy matching, which permits minor spelling variations in names, than under exact matching, which requires perfect agreement. The choice between exact and fuzzy matching involves a tradeoff between Type I errors (false positives) and Type II errors (false negatives). Given the lack of information in the postmaster data (e.g., there is no information on birth year to identify an individual further), the risk of false positives is a central concern. I therefore prioritize minimizing Type I errors and rely on exact matching in the main analysis. This reflects a judgment call that prioritizes precision over quantity, which is what I find more appropriate given the limitations of the data.

Next, I show that married women (indicated by the prefix "Mrs.") are slightly more likely to be linked than single women (indicated by the prefix "Miss"), but the difference is relatively modest. Table A8 below shows 42.3% of women postmasters with the prefix "Miss" and 45% of women postmasters with the prefix "Mrs." could be linked to the 1940 census. The size of the difference remains similar when I change the matching criteria from exact to fuzzy. In addition, when I further require that women's prefixes align with their marital status—dropping matches where "Mrs." is paired with a single marital status or "Miss" with a non-single status—the linking rates improve slightly, as the restriction makes it easier to identify unique matches.

In addition, I show that urban and rural postmasters have similar linking rates in Table A9. Although the postmaster appointment data does not directly provide information on the rural or urban status of postmasters, I can use classifications of the post office from the postal guide as proxies (United States Government Printing Office, 1939). Class 1 and Class 2 post offices are in densely populated areas (considered "urban"), and Class 3 post offices are in less populated areas (considered "rural"). I show that the differences in linking rates between urban and rural women are less than 1 pp. (columns 2 and 4), and the differences in linking rates between urban and rural men are around 1-3.4 pp. (columns 1 and 3).

Table A7: Linking Rates for Postmasters By Different Criteria

	(1) % >= 1 Match	(2) % Uniq Match	(3) % Uniq Match (Men)	(4) % Uniq Match (Women)
State, First Name & Last Name (Exact)	68.5	22.0	21.3	24.9
State, County, First & Last Name (Exact)	48.1	33.9	32.6	39.1
State, First Name & Last Name (Fuzzy)	84.6	16.3	15.9	17.8
State, County, First & Last Name (Fuzzy)	60.9	39.0	37.1	46.8

The table shows the linking rates between the postmaster data and the 1940 census based on different criteria: (a) exact match on state, first and last names (b) exact match on state, county, first and last names (c) exact match on state, fuzzy match on first and last names (d) exact match on state and county, fuzzy match on first and last names. The first two columns show the share of postmasters (1) with at least one match, but the match might not be unique (2) with a unique match. And the last two columns show the share of male and female postmasters with a unique match.

12.4 Comparison Between Linked and Census Samples of Postmasters

I compare the linked sample and the census sample of postmasters here. The census sample of postmasters is identified by the occupation code (occ1950=270) and taken from the 1940

Table A8: Linking Rates for Women Postmasters By Different Prefixes

	(1) % Unique Match "Miss"	(2) % Unique Match "Mrs"	(3) % Unique Match No Prefix
State, County, First Name & Last Name (Exact) No restrictions on marital status	42.3	45.0	32.2
State, County, First Name & Last Name (Exact) Restrictions on marital status	42.7	46.3	31.2
State, County, First Name & Last Name (Fuzzy) No restrictions on marital status	51.5	53.4	38.8
State, County, First Name & Last Name (Fuzzy) Restrictions on marital status	53.7	56.0	38.8

The table shows the linking rates between women postmasters and the 1940 census based on different criteria: (a) exact match on state, county, first and last names without restrictions on martial status (b) exact match on state, county, first and last names with restrictions on martial status (c) exact match on state and county, fuzzy match on first and last names, without restrictions on martial status (d) exact match on state and county, fuzzy match on first and last names, with restrictions on martial status. Restrictions on marital status mean I drop the observations where a postmaster with the prefix "Miss" is matched with a married woman in the census and where a postmaster with the prefix "Mrs" is matched with a single woman in the census. The columns show the share of postmasters with unique matches in the group where (1) the prefix is "Miss" (2) the prefix is "Mrs", and (3) there is no prefix.

Table A9: Linking Rates by Urban/Rural Status

	(1) % Uniq Match Urban Men	(2) % Uniq Match Urban Women	(3) % Uniq Match Rural Men	(4) % Uniq Match Rural Women
State, County, First & Last Name (Exact)	32.0	39.8	33.0	39.0
State, County, First & Last Name (Fuzzy)	35.0	46.8	38.4	46.8

The table shows the linking rates for postmasters by their urban and rural status. Urban and rural status of the postmaster is proxied by the classification of the post office, where Class 1 and 2 are considered urban post offices and Class 3 is considered rural post offices. The table also shows linking rates by different criteria: (a) exact match on state and county, exact match on first and last names; (b) exact match on state and county, fuzzy match on first and last names.

census. To further restrict this sample to include only presidential postmasters who worked full-time positions, I limit it to individuals earning at least $1,100 per year, which is the income threshold used by the Postal Guide to distinguish presidential from non-presidential postmasters (United States Government Printing Office, 1939). The linked sample of postmasters used in the comparison is those appointed after the 1933 presidential transition, who were likely still serving as postmasters at the time of the 1940 Census. I include two linked samples constructed using different matching criteria: one based on exact matches and the other on fuzzy matches.

Table A10 shows the observed characteristics of the linked sample and census sample of postmasters by gender. Based on Columns 1, 3, and 5, both groups of women had similar educational attainment (around 12.0–12.1 years) and were close in age (46.1–46.4 years). Nearly all women in both groups were White and native-born, consistent with the broader demographic patterns described in the paper. However, linked women postmasters were somewhat less likely to reside in urban areas (12.7–13.2%) compared to their census counterparts (15.8%), and were 2-3 pp. more likely to be married. Since married and rural women might be less likely to be employed after their postmaster appointments (due to marriage bars and availability of jobs), this overrepresentation may introduce a small upward bias in the RD estimates. However, it is unlikely to explain the substantial differences in employment outcomes we have observed in the paper.

In addition, all individuals in the census sample of postmasters were, by construction, recorded as employed, since the sample was identified based on the postmaster occupation code. In contrast, individuals in the linked sample of postmasters were less likely to report being employed in 1940. The employment gap between the two groups was relatively small for men (approximately 3–4 pp.), but more pronounced for women (about 13 pp.). This pattern may reflect the tendency of women to underreport employment in the census, even when they were working, possibly due to social stigma. The direction of any resulting bias in the RD estimate is unclear, as it depends on the degree of underreporting among women appointed just before versus just after the presidential transition. If both groups of women underreported employment to a similar extent, then the RD estimate would not be substantially biased.

12.5 RD Effects on Household Economic Outcomes

Did postmaster employment have an impact beyond individual-level outcomes? To address this question, I examine RD effects on household-level outcomes, including household income, homeownership, and house value in 1940 as shown in Figure A9 and Table A11.

First, household income is measured using both the wife's and the husband's wage income, conditional on the sample of married women postmasters. I find a difference of $702 in women's 1940 wage income between those appointed just before and just after the 1933 transition, reflecting a mechanical decline in earnings as many women exited the labor force.[28] In contrast, there is little evidence of a corresponding change in husbands' wage income, suggesting that husbands did not work more in response to the wife's job loss.

Turning to housing outcomes, I find little evidence of an RD effect on either homeownership or house value at the 1933 transition, suggesting that losing the postmaster appointment did not make women postmasters less likely to own a home or to reside in lower-value housing in 1940. One plausible explanation is that a substantial share of women postmasters already owned their homes prior to appointment (66.4% in 1920, as shown in Table 1), limiting the amount of changes we can observe.

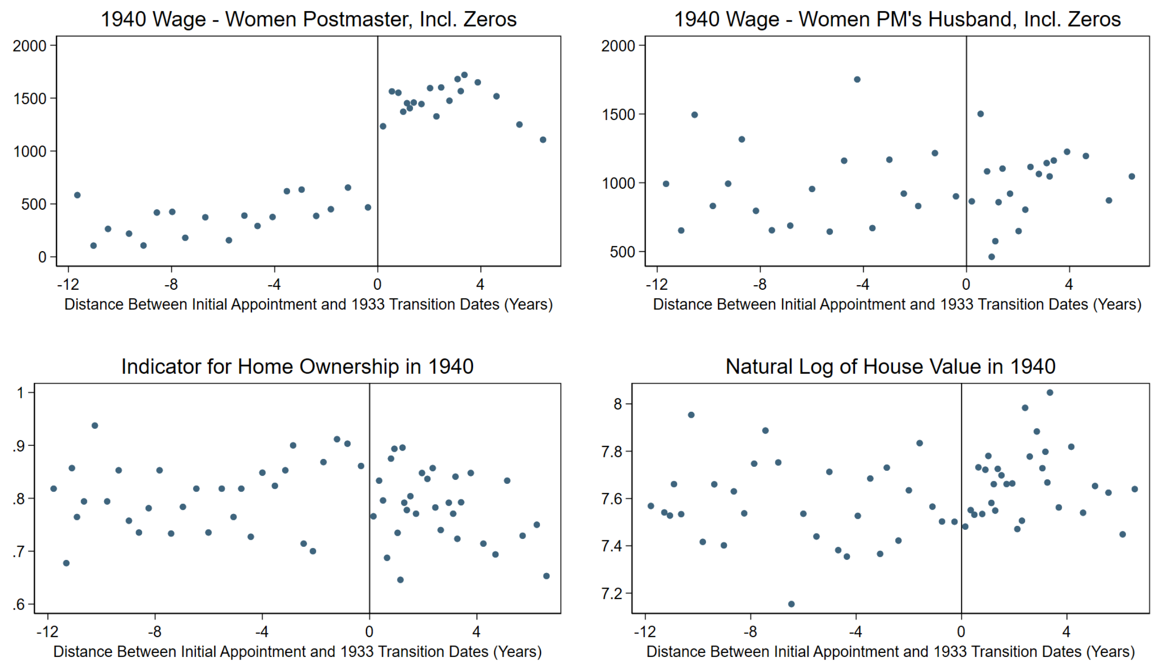
[28] As shown in Section 8, women who remained employed after their postmaster appointments earned wages comparable to women who continued serving as postmasters, implying that the observed decline in earnings is driven primarily by labor force exit rather than lower wages among those who continued working.

Table A10: Descriptive Statistics Between the Linked Sample and the Census Sample of Postmasters

	(1) Linked Exact Women	(2) Linked Exact Men	(3) Linked Fuzzy Women	(4) Linked Fuzzy Men	(5) Census Women	(6) Census Men
Education	12.1	11.2	12.0	11.3	12.1	11.3
	(2.5)	(3.0)	(2.6)	(3.0)	(2.6)	(2.8)
Age	46.1	48.0	46.2	48.3	46.4	49.0
	(10.8)	(12.0)	(11.0)	(12.0)	(10.7)	(11.1)
White	99.6	99.4	99.3	99.4	99.5	99.8
	(6.3)	(7.6)	(8.6)	(7.5)	(6.7)	(4.2)
Nativeborn	98.6	97.7	98.1	97.6	97.9	97.1
	(11.9)	(15.0)	(13.7)	(15.2)	(14.3)	(16.8)
Urban	12.7	25.9	13.2	25.4	15.8	32.5
	(33.3)	(43.8)	(33.8)	(43.5)	(36.5)	(46.8)
Farm	10.9	10.3	11.5	10.5	9.8	7.7
	(31.2)	(30.4)	(31.9)	(30.7)	(29.8)	(26.7)
Married	54.0	86.1	54.7	86.8	51.3	89.3
	(49.9)	(34.6)	(49.8)	(33.9)	(50.0)	(30.9)
Gainfully Employed	87.5	96.9	86.4	96.6	100.0	100.0
	(33.1)	(17.3)	(34.3)	(18.0)	(0.0)	(0.0)
Self-Employed	1.4	7.9	1.5	7.5	0.6	0.6
	(11.9)	(26.9)	(12.0)	(26.3)	(7.7)	(7.8)
Wage	1515.8	1870.6	1512.1	1882.4	1724.2	2152.1
	(798.0)	(1005.8)	(818.6)	(989.5)	(607.0)	(767.5)
N	1441	4386	1759	4912	4215	14365
Restricting the Sample to Household Head/Spouse						
Own Home	77.3	74.6	76.2	75.7	75.4	77.5
	(41.9)	(43.5)	(42.6)	(42.9)	(43.1)	(41.8)
# Children	1.1	1.4	1.1	1.4	1.0	1.4
	(1.3)	(1.5)	(1.3)	(1.5)	(1.3)	(1.5)
N	1149	3909	1391	4414	3306	13281

The table shows descriptive statistics between the linked sample of postmasters appointed after the 1933 presidential transition and the census sample of postmasters. The mean education/age/wage/number of children and the average share of white/native-born/urban/farm/married/employed/self-employed/homeowner population are reported. The linked sample of postmasters is reweighted by inverse probability weights (Bailey et al., 2020).

Figure A9: RD Figures on Household Outcomes



The RD figures plot (1) the 1940 wage for women postmasters, conditional on the postmaster being married; (2) the women postmasters' husbands' wage, conditional on the postmaster being married; (3) an indicator for homeownership in 1940; (4) the natural log of reported house value in 1940, conditional on homeownership. The running variable is the standardized distance between the initial appointment and the 1933 presidential transition dates. Data are plotted in quantile-spaced bins and are weighted by inverse probability weights.

Table A11: RD Results on Household Outcomes

	(1) Women PM's Wage	(2) Women PM Husband's Wage	(3) Home- ownership	(4) Log of House Value
RD Estimate	701.975**	560.961	-0.135	0.066
	(267.36)	(449.91)	(0.07)	(0.29)
N	1028	1109	2443	1883

The RD table shows the results for the following outcome variables (1) the 1940 wage for women postmasters, conditional on the postmaster being married; (2) the women postmasters' husbands' wage, conditional on the postmaster being married; (3) an indicator for homeownership in 1940; (4) the natural log of reported house value in 1940, conditional on homeownership. Standard errors are clustered by the running variable. Data are re-weighted by inverse probability weights. * for $p < 0.05$, ** for $p < 0.01$, *** for $p < 0.001$